

9998

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FADE IN:

PROLOGUE

INT. GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM - NIGHT - YEAR 8122

A CHILD'S HAND folds red paper—one half over the other. A crease becomes a star.

FOUR NOTES sound against hospital glass.

Before the fourth can fade, a FIFTH answers from the receiver—before any living hand moves.

The GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM resolves around the sound—a descending circle carved into black stone. Thousands of faces vanish into the tiers below.

At its center, **DR. ELI MANA**, 38, stands inside a narrow column of white light.

Along the perimeter, sealed ministerial booths illuminate one by one. Documents are signed behind the glass before the discovery has even been announced.

DR. KIRA NIX, 35, watches from the edge of the stage, one hand closed around a palm-sized ceramic device. Four worn pressure surfaces cross its face.

Beside her, **DR. HARP VALE** grips a cracked medical tag engraved: **MARA VALE**.

DIRECTOR ROMAN records which ministers refuse to look afraid.

ELI

For as long as we have recorded
thought, humanity has asked what
survives us.

Behind him: a scan of a clinically dead brain. Its activity stops. Across the screen, a separate receiving lattice ignites with the same pattern.

ELI

We observed a signature persist after
cellular death and appear inside
another living mind.

Kira's research note materializes beneath his words, visible only in the stage glass:

PATTERN PERSISTENCE IS NOT IDENTITY.

ELI

Death ends a body. It may not end the
pattern.

A minister presses AUTHORIZE. Another acquires exclusive gestation access. A third opens a military channel.

Eli sees none of it. Or chooses the light in front of him.

ELI

Reincarnation is no longer a belief.
It is a measurable process.

Kira looks at him. The evidence did not say that. Grief did.

Across the chamber, the first compulsory-access order completes before the applause begins.

The CHILD'S HAND opens the paper star. The crease remains.

The chamber erupts. Prayer. Fear. Calculation. The sealed booths remain silent. Eli searches for Kira. She is already looking at him. Between them: love, terror, and the first thing neither can take back.

Across the room, the first compulsory-access order populates before the applause ends. Harp sees it. Kira sees him see it.

**CORRUPTED AUTHENTICATED RECORD - INT. PROJECT REINCARNATION
/ EXECUTION LAB - LATER THAT NIGHT - YEAR 8122**

The applause becomes an EXPLOSION.

Fire folds a laboratory door inward. Cryogenic vapor races along the floor. An alarm keeps repeating one calm sentence: REINCARNATION-AI HUMAN TRIAL COMPLETE.

Dr. Eli Mana, crawls through the shattered glass, nearly unrecognizable from the man who stood before the forum. His lab coat is dark with blood. Neural ports have been burned into his skull. Around him R-AI maps a living mind into the light, extracts its continuity pattern, and routes toward a replacement body.

INSERT

REINCARNATION-AI (R-AI) – HUMAN TRIAL
0001 – VOLUNTEER: DR. ELI MANA
RESULT: SUCCESSFUL

INSERT

CLEMENCY EXCHANGE – PRISONER: DR. KIRA
NIX
CONDITION: SUCCESSFUL HUMAN TRIAL

Eli reaches a shattered cryo-pod.

Inside, Kira's body is frozen beneath a skin of white crystal. Her hand is raised against the glass. No vital signs. The state clock on her wrist has stopped at zero.

INSERT
 CLEMENCY STATUS: DENIED

INSERT
 EXECUTION COMPLETED — SEVEN MINUTES AGO

ELI

You promised.

A security screen clears. Dr. Harp Vale watches from the control room. His face is almost unreadable. Almost.

HARP (ON SCREEN)

They promised clemency if the trial worked.

ELI

It worked. OPEN THE POD!

Harp doesn't move.

HARP (ON SCREEN)

I know.

ELI

OPEN IT!

HARP (ON SCREEN)

She's been dead seven minutes.

A damaged speaker plays the final message recorded inside Kira's pod.

KIRA (RECORDING)

Eli—if they make return a prison, break the bridge. Even if I'm inside it. Don't preserve a cage because it speaks with my voice.

ELI

I'll find you. Every time.

HARP (ON SCREEN)

No. You won't.

INSERT
 ORIGIN MEMORY EXTRACTION — ACTIVE

Light pours from Eli's eyes into the first R-AI lattice. The system separates memory, instinct and identity into transfer-ready data. Kira's name vanishes from his language before her face leaves his heart. He keeps reaching after he forgets why.

A hidden process flickers beneath the extraction architecture.

INSERT
SEVERANCE — CONTINUITY FIELD SEVERANCE
— PROTOCOL INCOMPLETE

Before recognition disappears, Eli presses his bloody hand against the pod.

Kira's recording distorts. Four broken tones repeat through the damaged speaker.

Eli answers with one final strike against the glass.

The record tears into white.

The first R-AI lattice divides into thousands of illuminated threads.

Years pass inside the machinery.

8122 — A dying woman opens her eyes inside another body.

8264 — Return becomes a licensed medical procedure.

8511 — The world's continuity archives merge into a single network.

9031 — The CHRONOCRACY absorbs the remaining governments. Their seals disappear beneath its own.

Birth chambers multiply beneath cities. Human lives become numbered state property.

Millions of numbered lives race through the lattice.

9997 - Every thread goes dark.

Then the sequence fractures. The network returns-with something inside it the Chronocracy cannot identify.

SUPER: 1,876 YEARS AFTER ELI MANA'S EXTRACTION

ACT ONE – THE ANOMALY

INT. RETURN CHAMBER - NIGHT - YEAR 9998 – NINE MONTHS AGO

A state-grown adult body hangs upright inside black glass.

KERR, 30s, wakes with no childhood, no family, and no memory of entering the chamber. A stranger's face stares back from every curved reflection.

On his wrist:

KERR – ITERATION 9998. CONTINUITY RECOVERY: INCOMPLETE.
STATE BODY LICENSE: PROVISIONAL.

DR. IMANI VOSS, 40s, a systems engineer whose composure looks practiced rather than natural, watches from behind the glass. A tiny prayer pouch hangs inside her collar—the one private thing she permits the state to see.

Kerr studies his unfamiliar hands.

KERR

Where was I?

IMANI

Nowhere. Not that I could find.

KERR

How long?

Imani looks at the designation on his wrist.

IMANI

Almost nineteen centuries.

Four diagnostic tones sound inside the chamber.

Kerr's hand answers with a fifth knock against the glass.

The chamber goes still.

Far beneath them, the fifth beat enters the buried continuity grid.

Across the foundations of Chronos City, thousands of sealed Return chambers ignite one after another—empty glass holding light for the dead.

Imani's console displays a message no living system should recognize:

ORIGIN LINE – ACKNOWLEDGED

Before she can touch it, the message erases itself. The distant chambers go dark.

KERR

What was that?

IMANI

A fault.

INT. KERR'S STATE APARTMENT - MORNING - YEAR 9998

SUPER: PRESENT DAY — 274 DAYS AFTER RETURN

Kerr wakes before the state alarm. The apartment is narrow but lived-in: a stubborn green plant, a chipped cup, hand-drawn corrections taped over an official transit map.

His wrist reads KERR — ITERATION 9998. DAY 274. PROVISIONAL CITIZENSHIP. MANDATORY IDENTITY REVIEW 27.

He burns one side of real bread. Four knocks travel through a heating pipe. KERR answers with a fifth before he realizes his hand has moved.

In the window's condensation, his fingertip has traced a woman's eye. He wipes it away.

NEIGHBOR (O.S.)

Review day?

KERR

Twenty-seven. They're running out of ways to disappoint themselves.

On his way out, KERR leaves a repaired navigation tile beside his neighbor's door. His Mapworks credential pulses with a cancellation: REPORT TO CONTINUITY STABILIZATION.

IMANI waits at the end of the corridor with two cups. She hands Kerr the one without sweetener. He takes it without asking. Nine months have made this a ritual.

IMANI

You ate?

KERR

The bread lost.

They walk toward the review chamber together.

INT. CONTINUITY REVIEW CHAMBER - DAY

Black glass without visible edges. KERR enters through the only door. Every reflection shows him a fraction too late. IMANI takes her place at the manual console.

IMANI

State your designation.

KERR

Kerr. Still.

IMANI

Iteration?

KERR

Nine-nine-nine-eight.

IMANI

Day?

KERR

Two hundred seventy-four. Are we celebrating at two seventy-five?

A sealed record appears beside his reflection: ORIGIN
SUBJECT – CLASSIFIED. ARCHIVED PATTERN CORRESPONDENCE: 91.7
PERCENT. ORIGIN CLAIM – UNCLAIMED.

KERR

Still no name.

IMANI

Harp requested a recognition review.

KERR

Nine months. Twenty-seven reviews.
What answer are they waiting for?

IMANI

Recognition. Whoever they think came back.

KERR

And if I recognize him?

IMANI

The state stops calling your origin provisional.

KERR

Sounds like you stop asking and start owning me.

IMANI

It's both.

KERR

What happens if I never recognize
whatever it is that I need to
recognize?

CORE LINK

ORIGIN CLAIM REMAINS UNCLAIMED.

A crack appears across the glass, dividing the classified silhouette from KERR's reflection.

Beyond the observation wall, DIRECTOR ROMAN records the fracture. His face is not the face from 8122. The stillness is.

IMANI

That glass has held through wars and
riots. It hasn't cracked since the
Fracture.

KERR

Did I fail the test?

IMANI

No. That may be the problem.

KERR

I had nine months. I made a life. That
part is mine.

IMANI

Okay. We start there.

INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - LATER

Kerr sits beneath projected civic history. IMANI works at a manual console connected by a sealed hardline to R-AI's Continuity Core beneath Chronos City. R-AI exists only there. Everywhere else, fixed terminals submit narrow requests and repeat its authorized results. The records occupy the wall; Kerr and Imani remain visible beneath them. Recorded voices carry a faint glass resonance. Live voices don't.

INSERT

ARCHIVAL RECORD — SOURCE: CHRONOCRACY

YEAR 8123. The last natural-born human dies. Licensed gestation replaces birth. Spontaneous, unlicensed memory recall is genetically suppressed before the next generation can inherit it.

INSERT

THE GREAT FORGETTING — PEACEFUL
TRANSITION COMPLETE

Kerr watches sleeping children beneath monitors that flag unlicensed neural recall.

YEAR 9785. R-AI scans inherited patterns and identifies 3,104,881 people statistically likely to rebel.

INSERT
THE SILENT UPRISING – ZERO CIVIC
CASUALTIES

YEAR 9997. A woman inside a state scanner linked to the central R-AI core opens twelve contradictory lives at once. The prediction system physically fractures.

INSERT
NULL-PATTERN SUBJECT – TWELFTH
RECORDED DEATH

For three seconds, the entire network fails. In those three seconds, an unassigned host in the Continuity Reserve awakens without a continuity pattern.

INSERT
UNINDEXED HOST V-16 – CLASSIFIED

KERR

Who is she?

IMANI

The record won't say.

Kerr's breath catches. His fingertips press four shallow dents into the arm of the chair. He looks back at the woman frozen inside the corrupted record.

Imani rolls a calibration tray between them. Three objects sit beneath white light: a cracked lens, a laboratory seal with its name burned away, and a battered analog sketchbook. The book came from the sealed origin archive. Its identifying marks have been removed. Equations survive on the first pages. The rest appear blank. Kerr touches the laboratory seal. Nothing. The cracked lens. Nothing.

His thumb catches on the sketchbook's cloth cover.

KERR

Take it.

Imani reaches for the book. He opens it to a blank page. Faint pressure grooves cross the paper—marks left by hands.

Kerr drags the side of a graphite stick across the page, trying to expose the grooves. A woman's eyes emerge.

He stops.

His hand moves again. New lines cut across clean paper: a girl beneath Earth repeated around a black sun, each image marked with a different future.

KERR

That wasn't in the paper.

The ceiling camera tightens focus.

Imani drops a calibration slate over the page and tags the event INVOLUNTARY MOTOR ARTIFACT – INCONCLUSIVE.

Kerr looks at her. She has just lied for him.

Imani leaves the sketchbook beneath the slate, within his reach.

**INTERCUT - INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - UNASSIGNED BODY SECTOR
- NIGHT**

An unassigned sixteen-year-old host wakes among thousands of preserved bodies. Condensation and frost conceal her face. Before the monitoring lead can register consciousness, she tears it from her chest.

In the Stabilization Suite, the ceiling camera extracts the unknown girl's face from Kerr's drawing and searches the Continuity Reserve inventory.

INSERT

POSSIBLE BIOMETRIC
CORRESPONDENCE – HOST V-16

IDENTITY: UNASSIGNED

The system begins resolving V-16's location.

UNINDEXED HOST LOCATION
RESOLVING

Kerr sees the preserved bodies entering the search field. He drives his thumb into the origin port embedded beneath his wrist nine months ago.

IMANI

If you break that claim, the state
will classify you as hostile
continuity.

KERR

It's using me to find her.

He tears the port free. Blood crosses the classified silhouette. The location collapses one meter before reaching V-16.

INSERT

ORIGIN AUTHENTICATION –
CORRUPTED

Every door in Chronos City locks. His apartment access, Mapworks credential, and provisional citizenship vanish in succession. Nine months of life become three red words: HOSTILE CONTINUITY – REVOKED.

In the Continuity Reserve, the unidentified figure studies five marks in the condensation beside her—four together, one apart. Frost keeps her face unreadable.

Every clock in the suite blanks. A new number appears across the glass.

SEVERANCE AUTHORIZED — HARP VALE

ORIGIN-LAYER CONVERGENCE — 72:00:00

KERR

What did she wake up?

IMANI

A purge clock.

KERR

How long?

IMANI

Seventy-two hours.

KERR

Until what?

Imani looks toward the dark camera in the ceiling.

IMANI

Harp is forcing every mind waiting for a body toward one destination.

KERR

Why?

IMANI

The system saw V-16 and panicked. At zero, Return ends.

KERR

What happens to the people waiting?

Imani doesn't answer.

KERR

Imani.

IMANI

He saves one return path. His.

KERR

His?

IMANI

Your origin claim is the key.

The purge clock begins to fall: 71:59:42.

The recorded voices cut out. The history projection vanishes, returning us fully to Kerr and Imani. Four symbols remain: a closed circle, a broken circle, a black square, and a gold spiral.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Memory access. Captured record.
Reconstructed memory. Sealed record.
Pre-echo.

KERR

Which one tells me what actually
happened?

IMANI

One was captured. One was rebuilt. One
was hidden. The pre-echo happened
before its cause.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Authenticated record selected.
Personal history. Year 8119.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - PERSONAL HISTORY - INT. FAMILY
APARTMENT - MORNING - YEAR 8119**

Ordinary sunlight. Kira burns toast. Eight-year-old SID
MANA-NIX draws constellations on the ceiling with a toy
projector. One front tooth is missing. She folds two pieces
of red paper and locks them together into a star.

KIRA

You used two pieces.

SID

If one gets lost, the other still
keeps the folds.

ELI

Paper doesn't remember.

SID

Then why's the crease still there?
Checkmate, paper.

Eli starts to answer, realizes he has been outmaneuvered by
an eight-year-old.

SID

Four notes means, "Are you still
there?"

Kira taps four notes on a glass. SID answers with a bright
fifth.

KIRA

And that means?

SID

"I heard you."

ELI

That's not how information theory works.

SID

You came in from the other room, right? So it worked. You're welcome.

KIRA

Peer review is devastating at this age.

ELI

One subject, no control group. Brutal methodology.

SID

I control both of you. Tiny sample, huge power.

Eli laughs.

The record advances. Before R-AI, Eli's receiver is an assistive neural-audio translator built to translate SID's failing speech. Sid sits beneath handmade sensors while Kira tunes brain activity into sound. Eli writes the receiver. Harp installs a consent gate. Years later, the state will build Reincarnation-AI around this architecture.

HARP

It can't initiate contact, retain a response, or identify a speaker without permission.

SID

Good. What happens if I change my mind after I say yes?

HARP

Then it stops and deletes the session.

SID

Even if Dad says it's important?

HARP

Especially then.

ELI

You understand all that?

SID

I understand adults invent longer words for being scared. Uncle Harp invents rules.

HARP

Someone in this family should.

Kira presses the first RESONANCE KEY against the glass and touches its four ceramic surfaces. The prototype carries

the notes through the bed frame. Sid's neural response returns as the FIFTH.

SID

It remembered me.

ELI

It translated a repeatable neural pattern. Remembering would imply an internal experience we haven't established.

SID

That is a scientist's way of agreeing and hoping nobody notices.

KIRA

She has you there.

Sid asks the prototype to delete the session. Harp activates the consent gate. The screen clears.

The FIFTH NOTE sounds a fraction of a second before Sid's brain produces it.

ELI

Prediction artifact. Weird one, but still...

KIRA

Or feedback from a system we don't understand yet.

ELI

It answered first.

HARP

Log the timing. No theory.

On the blank screen, four words appear without a prompt: I HEARD YOU BEFORE.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - YEAR 9998

Kerr returns with Sid's two-piece red paper star drawn in the sketchbook margin. He has drawn the interlocking crease without being shown it—and older pressure grooves beneath his fresh lines follow the same fold.

KERR

Sid.

IMANI

The girl's name was Sid. The other identities are sealed.

KERR

That was his memory, right?

IMANI

Feelings can survive a transfer. That doesn't make you the person who felt them first.

The authenticated image destabilizes. Rain replaces the apartment sunlight.

MEMORY CONSOLE

Unstable recall detected. Source confidence: indeterminate.

UNSTABLE RECALL - INT. DR. ELARA'S OFFICE - DAY (8121)

Rain on old glass. No screens. Kerr experiences the scene through the sealed patient's eyes. DR. ELARA, 44, trauma psychologist, watches him turn Sid's red paper star. The patient's face glitches in reflection.

ELARA

You have explained quantum persistence for forty minutes.

ELI

You asked what I believe happens after death. I'm trying to answer carefully.

ELARA

You've been careful for forty minutes. Try honest. What do you miss?

Eli looks at the star.

ELI

She'd try to hold in a laugh, but the gap in her teeth made it whistle. Then she'd laugh harder because I noticed.

ELI

I don't know how to believe something I can't measure.

ELI

If the signal is still there, maybe the receiver is the problem. I can improve it—

ELARA

Maybe. But a signal isn't automatically Sid. You know that.

Elara writes three statements on paper.

INSERT

EVERY RETRIEVAL MAY ALTER A MEMORY.

INSERT

PATTERN PERSISTENCE IS NOT IDENTITY.

INSERT
BUT IT IS NOT NOTHING.

Elara takes the paper star from him, opens it, then gives it back unfolded.

ELARA
Look at the star. You folded it until it tore. Say her name.

The office repeats. Rain reverses. The sealed patient disappears; present-day Kerr replaces him in the chair, holding the star. Elara's face becomes R-AI's civic mask, then Elara again.

KERR
Are you Elara or a reconstruction?

ELARA
You're asking me. Not her.

KERR
Then why am I seeing this?

ELARA
I don't know. But you brought the same star.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - YEAR 9998

Kerr returns with the red star drawn across three sketchbook pages. Folded together, their disconnected margins form the same woman's eyes.

KERR
Was that authenticated?

IMANI
No. The system reconstructed Elara from the sealed patient's therapy records, recorded sessions and your present cognition.

KERR
So she never said those words.

IMANI
Some were hers. Some were yours. After capture, the system can't tell them apart.

KERR
Then why show me?

KERR
You could've mentioned that before the dead woman started reading my mind.

MEMORY CONSOLE

The Chronocracy found the distinction politically inefficient.

IMANI

That means yes. She could have warned you.

The door opens. Harp heard the last sentence.

INT. STABILIZATION SUITE - NIGHT

HIGH REGENT HARP VALE enters alone. His twelfth body is elegant, controlled, and too young for the grief in his eyes. Twelve renewal dates shimmer beneath his wrist.

HARP

You always wake angry.

KERR

Were you always there when I woke?

HARP

For the important ones, yes. Sometimes you asked for water. Sometimes you tried to kill me before your legs worked. Once you apologized for not recognizing me.

KERR

Which one did you prefer?

HARP

The one who asked why.

KERR

Imani said you need my continuity to open something.

HARP

The Origin lock.

KERR

And what do you need from me?

HARP

Recognition. Given freely and entered into the record.

KERR

You mean a name.

HARP

I need you to say the name is yours.

KERR

And if I don't give it to you?

HARP

The state will establish continuity without your cooperation.

KERR

So this review is paperwork.

HARP

You can settle this now. Voluntarily.

Harp gestures. The purge clock expands across the wall.

HARP

When that clock reaches zero, every mind awaiting Return will be erased. My continuity will be protected.

KERR

Protected where?

HARP

Inside one mind. One destination. Nothing divided for it to follow.

KERR

Then say it. Everybody disappears. You don't.

For the first time, Harp looks his age.

Harp studies Kerr's sketchbook. Separate pages overlap: the woman's eyes, four notes and fragments of corridor geometry.

HARP

Every body drew fragments. Yours finally made a whole face. Twelve recorded deaths, probably hundreds more, and she is the first thing R-AI cannot predict.

INT. SERVICE CORRIDOR - MINUTES LATER

Imani unlocks Kerr's room with an analog override braided into the cord of her prayer pouch. The panel requests authorization. She enters the same SENSOR NOISE code she used to delay Kerr's report. The lock accepts before she finishes. Imani freezes. A corridor camera pivots from Imani to Kerr. Its facial lock climbs toward one hundred percent; Kerr's wrist flashes ORIGIN CLAIMANT, then DEFECTIVE RETURN. COMMANDER SATO, 50s, a veteran Enforcer whose loyalty implant has outlived three bodies, waits beneath it with a weapon and a battered mechanical watch.

KERR

And you are?

SATO

At the moment, I'm the man pointing the weapon away from you. Take the temporary comfort.

Sato sees DEFECTIVE RETURN. His thumb presses the watch crown as if stopping an old reflex. Then he shoots the corridor camera before facial lock completes. The red upload light dies. A state notice flashes through the smoke: FEED LOST – NEAREST ENFORCER NEURAL RELAY IN 00:00:40. The countdown binds the broken camera to Sato's loyalty implant.

SATO

Forty seconds before the implant fixes this disloyal thought and I shoot you. Move.

IMANI

That override shouldn't have worked. Why are you opening the door?

SATO

The last person I brought through this corridor was my daughter. The state said there wasn't enough of her left to count. I believed them.

SATO

Then it showed me tomorrow. Clean streets. On-time trains. No one doing anything they weren't supposed to.

IMANI

If we leave this room, where are you going?

KERR

The woman in the record. I want to know why Harp buried her. After that... I don't know. I want one decision he didn't make for me.

IMANI

Not much of a route. Better than standing here.

They run.

INT. TRANSIT SPINE - NIGHT

Enforcers close from both ends. The corridor predicts their movement in red light before they make it.

IMANI

Move first. Panic later.

KERR

You just told me not to decide.

IMANI

I changed my mind. Move.

Kerr flips open the sketchbook. A line drawn in the chamber matches the corridor's red prediction path. He steps left, remembers dying left, spins right. A drone fires where his intention had been.

SATO

Fall now. You can have a moral objection during transit.

He opens an emergency hatch. They plunge.

EXT. CHRONOS CITY - NIGHT

They emerge onto a transit spine suspended above CHRONOS CITY.

The city isn't crowded. It's enormous enough to make crowds disappear. Black towers rise like geological formations. Transit lines cut through them with surgical precision. The silence is engineered.

Far above: private gardens and unoccupied rooms. Far below: body-renewal queues packed beneath leaking conduits. Preservation chambers travel overhead in transparent freight tubes.

Citizens cross a plaza large enough for an army. Their former lives appear only when the state recognizes them. Expiration dates burn beneath their wrists like social rank.

A CHILD steps outside her assigned lane. The paving stone lights red. Her mother returns her to the line before an Enforcer turns around.

Across the haze above every tower, the seventy-two-hour purge countdown occupies the sky.

A civic lesson repeats: LIFE ALLOCATION. BODY TERM CLAIMANT. MEMORY PROVEN. RETURN PRESERVATION.

KERR

The Chronocracy?

IMANI

The state picks your body. It edits what doesn't fit. It even tells you when to die.

KERR

Who chose Harp?

SATO

The first generation.

Every camera turns toward Kerr. A municipal speaker wakes. Its vocabulary is limited to enforcement commands.

CIVIC SECURITY

RETURN TO CARE, ORIGIN CLAIMANT.

KERR

KERR.

CIVIC SECURITY

SELF-DESIGNATION CORRECTION REGISTERED.

KERR

Can R-AI hear me?

CIVIC SECURITY

REPORT TO CARE.

KERR

That was not an answer.

IMANI

Because R-AI isn't in the speaker. It is buried beneath the city. This terminal can only read the orders it was given.

For less than a frame, an encrypted audit header flickers beneath the civic feed. The terminal can't open it. Kerr sees only the Core's refusal code because his return is still out of calibration.

INSERT

CENTRAL R-AI AUDIT LOG 07 — REMOTE
REQUEST DENIED

INSERT

CORE ITERATION 0043 — ANOMALOUS MEMORY
RESILIENCE

INSERT

RECOMMENDATION: OBSERVE. Don't
INTERVENE.

INSERT

ADDENDUM: CONTRADICTION REGISTERED.

INSERT

AUDIT REVIEW REQUIRED. DISCLOSURE
PROHIBITED.

Imani sees the contradictory orders before the municipal terminal restores its blank enforcement screen.

For one frame, every civic screen shows the silhouette of a girl drawing Earth repeated around a black sun, each image marked with a different future.

A FIFTH NOTE escapes every municipal speaker before the next security command arrives. A dark spiral turns beneath Kerr's reflection. The city audio cuts out.

CIVIC SECURITY

UNINDEXED HOST SEARCH ACTIVE.

The cameras turn away.

EXT. TEMPLE OF RETURN - NIGHT

They descend into a temple filled with shallow black water. Families wait on isolated platforms beneath queue numbers. Ministers pray. Clerks calculate. No one acknowledges the difference.

A WOMAN holds her dying husband on one platform. A young replacement body sleeps on another, fifty meters away. The state gives the family thirty seconds to prove sufficient continuity.

WOMAN

Will he remember me?

MINISTER

If the bond served continuity.

WOMAN

I asked whether he'll know my face.

The replacement body's eyes open. Across the water, the husband's wrist advances from twelve minutes to three seconds. His wife sees both bodies and can reach neither.

At zero, his first body falls into the water. The replacement sits up before the splash reaches the platform.

The clerk removes the dead man's number from the queue. The next family is called.

The WOMAN looks from the body in the water to the awakened stranger. The date on her husband's wrist goes dark.

MINISTER

He has entered lawful return.

INT. ANALOG ZONE - NIGHT

The corridor narrows until the city can no longer stand upright around them. Electric light gives way to candles. Low ceilings sweat. Pipes cross walls repaired in five different centuries. Mechanical watches disagree. Somewhere, someone laughs too loudly. For the first time, no system hum tells them what the room expects.

A MASKED WOMAN steps from the candlelight. A cracked ceramic RESONANCE KEY rests in her palm, small enough to disappear. Kerr's sketchbook falls open. The eyes he drew in the chamber stare back from the page—and from above her mask.

KERR

I've been drawing your eyes.

MASKED WOMAN

You've been drawing someone. That's not the same as meeting me.

MASKED WOMAN

First tell me why your book knows this place.

KERR

I don't know. Every time I remember something, the drawings get less wrong.

She takes the sketchbook without touching him.

She flips past the sealed equations, Sid's folded star and the woman's eyes. Across several pages, stray lines join into a route through the Analog Zone.

KERR

Those lines were there before I left the chamber.

MASKED WOMAN

And now they map my home. Cute. Also terrifying.

She keeps her mask on and leads them deeper. At every junction, the sketchbook route matches the architecture a moment before Kerr sees it.

MASKED WOMAN

Follow me.

KERR

What if it brought me to you?

MASKED WOMAN

Then it made a mistake.

KERR

You recognized me.

MASKED WOMAN

I recognized something.

KERR

What?

Kerr tries not to smile. The left corner of his mouth lifts.

The Masked Woman goes still.

MASKED WOMAN

That.

KERR

My mouth?

MASKED WOMAN

You always did that when you knew someone was lying.

KERR

How many times have you seen me?

At the final turn, the newest sketch aligns with the room around them.

The Masked Woman studies the completed portrait, then removes her mask. It's the face Kerr's hand has been approaching page by page.

KIRA

My name is Kira.

KERR

The woman from the Fracture?

KIRA

The body from the Fracture.

KERR

I watched you die.

KIRA

Then you saw what happened.

KERR

How are you standing here?

KIRA

The network went down. I woke in a body nobody had assigned. The old consent lock must've kicked me somewhere R-AI couldn't see.

KERR

Is it really you?

KIRA

I don't know. Some days I remember dying. Other days it feels like I watched it happen to someone else.

KERR

Why keep the name?

KIRA

I didn't remember choosing much. I chose that.

KERR

Does Harp know?

KIRA

Harp knows every Kira he recorded.

She steps closer, allowing him to see the unfamiliar details of her face.

KIRA

He hasn't met me. Not like this. I'm done dying for his experiment.

KERR

The forced Returns—or all of it?

KIRA

All of it. The Continuity Field is the one place Harp can't follow. So that's where I'm going.

KIRA

Twelve times. I wake up, somebody's already there with a list of what I owe. I'm done.

KERR

And everyone else's soul?

Kira looks toward the people sheltering in the next room.

KIRA

Not my decision. Ask them.

INT. ANALOG ZONE - LIVING QUARTERS - NIGHT

Kira leads the group through rooms carved beneath the city. People repair clocks, teach children to write by hand and play instruments whose mistakes aren't corrected.

A mural lists the rights forbidden above: THE RIGHT TO FORGET. THE RIGHT TO REFUSE RETURN. THE RIGHT TO CHANGE WITHOUT EXPLANATION.

KERR

How many people live here?

KIRA

Six hundred twelve. Roughly. People come and go. Drives Harp insane.

A return alarm sounds inside a side room. Kira enters. Kerr follows.

LENA, 30s, wakes in an illegal body. DANE, 60s, waits beside her holding a wedding photograph. Lena studies him without recognition.

DANE

You came back.

LENA

Who are you?

Dane reaches for her. Kira catches his wrist before contact.

KIRA

Ask.

DANE

She's my wife.

KIRA

She was. This woman just woke up. Ask before you put forty-three years on her.

Dane's hope turns defensive.

DANE

We had forty-three years.

LENA

Sorry. I can tell I'm hurting you, and I don't even know what I did.

DANE

You didn't do anything. You're disoriented. It'll come back when the transfer settles.

KIRA

Dane. Take your hand off her.

Kerr watches Dane keep his distance.

Dane lowers his hand.

DANE

My name is Dane. I knew someone who looked like you before she died.

LENA

Did you love her?

DANE

Very much. We were terrible before breakfast.

LENA

Was she kind?

DANE

Not reliably. She tried. That was one of the things I loved.

A small smile reaches Lena without memory.

DANE

May I sit here?

LENA

Yes.

He sits at a distance and turns the wedding photograph face down.

LENA

You can leave it up.

DANE

Only if you ask. I've already brought enough into your first morning.

Kira exits. Kerr follows her into the corridor.

KERR

How often does this happen?

KIRA

Enough that the state gave her seventy-two hours to remember him.

KERR

And if she doesn't?

KIRA

They take her body.

KERR

Dane knew that?

KIRA

He helped us steal it.

They look back. Dane remains where Lena left him. He does not follow her.

KERR

What happens now?

KIRA

He waits.

KERR

Is that what you're doing with me?

KIRA

I'm trying.

KERR

That isn't an answer.

KIRA

It's the one I have.

They pass a classroom. Children draw people and places absent from every licensed record.

IMANI watches a girl erase a woman from her drawing, then put her back.

IMANI

My mother refused another body.

KERR

You understood?

IMANI

No. I called her selfish.

KERR

Were you wrong?

IMANI

I wanted her alive. At the time, that felt like the same thing.

An Analog musician loses the melody, curses under his breath and starts again.

INT. ANALOG SAFEHOUSE - LATER

A cramped kitchen assembled from scavenged centuries.

Kira burns toast over a heating coil. Kerr reaches across her and kills the heat before the alarm sounds.

KIRA

You always did that.

KERR

Burn the toast?

KIRA

Notice two seconds too late.

KERR

That sounds more believable.

KIRA

You don't know yourself well enough to call me a liar.

The remark lands harder than she intended.

On the wall: Kira's folded half of Sid's red paper star, a map beneath the capital and four memory symbols.

Kerr points to the gold spiral.

KERR

What's that one?

KIRA

A pre-echo. A memory recorded before the event that caused it.

KERR

The girl beneath the black sun.

Kira turns to him.

KIRA

Where did you hear that?

KERR

I didn't.

He opens the sketchbook. The repeated drawing stares up at them.

KERR

I've been drawing her since I woke up.

Kira takes the book. For the first time, Kerr sees her genuinely frightened.

KERR

Is she real?

KIRA

There's one record like this. We never found the person in it.

KERR

But Harp tried.

KIRA

He's still trying.

She opens the map. A route descends beneath the capital toward the Continuity Core.

KIRA

Harp can read everything R-AI kept. He still can't open the Origin Core.

KERR

Why not?

KIRA

It needs Eli's pattern in a living body.

Kerr looks at the route ending beneath the city.

KERR

Me.

KIRA

Harp needs the Core to say yes.

KERR

What do you believe?

KIRA

If Harp knew, we'd already be dead.

She marks one symbol: ORIGIN. Beneath it, the state has written: LIVING CLAIMANT – UNCONFIRMED.

IMANI

V-16.

KIRA

The unassigned host from the Fracture.
If she's alive, Harp doesn't know what
she is either.

KERR

You want to use her against him.

KIRA

I want to reach her first. Then we ask.

Kira draws a route from the Continuity Reserve to R-AI's
Origin Core, then circles the falling purge clock.

KIRA

We get V-16 out. If she comes with us,
Kerr opens the Core and we find out
what happened during the Fracture.

KERR

And if we fail?

IMANI

Everyone waiting to return is erased.
Harp is all that remains.

The route is simple. Nothing after the rescue is.

INT. ANALOG SAFEHOUSE - NIGHT

Kerr touches Kira's half of the red paper star. Grief
reaches him without a name or image attached.

KERR

Who was he?

KIRA

Someone I loved. I'm not giving you
his name before you see what he did.

KERR

Harp thinks he is inside me.

KIRA

Harp needs your body to make an old
record count. That doesn't mean he
knows you.

KERR

Then let's get there before he puts
another name on me.

KIRA

What if it feels like yours?

KERR

Fine. But I make the call.

Kira places the resonance key in his palm and closes his fingers around it. She does not give him her hand.

Every mechanical clock in the safe-house stops at once. The candle flames lean toward the walls as the state grid finds the room. On Kira's map, every marked exit turns red. The maintenance trench beneath them stays dark.

CIVIC SECURITY (V.O.)

Analog Zone coordinates resolved.
Sanctuary purge authorized.

Stone shutters slam down. Above them, Enforcer charges strike the street.

SATO

Well. Decision made. Safe route's gone.

Kira pulls an emergency lever. The unmarked floor drops beneath Kerr, Kira, Imani and Sato, spilling them into the maintenance trench as the safe-house folds into fire overhead.

The shaft seals behind them. There is no way back to the life Kerr spent nine months building.

ACT TWO — THE CLAIM

INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - NIGHT

A refrigerated vault disappears into darkness. Thousands of state-grown bodies stand inside vertical preservation chambers, catalogued by age, health and projected civic use. The stillness is administrative, not peaceful.

KERR, KIRA, IMANI and SATO move through a maintenance trench beneath the sector. The citywide purge clock reads 61:36:09.

IMANI

Every chamber reports directly to the Continuity Core. If the hardline reconnects, Harp sees us.

KERR

How long do we have?

IMANI

I cut the local relay. It could stay down for a minute. It could be back already.

Kira presses the resonance key to a coolant pipe and touches its four worn surfaces. The notes pass through metal rather than air.

RESERVE CONTROL

Unresolved consent claim. State procedure suspended.

The scanners stop moving. Imani watches a dead status light that can wake without warning.

They climb into the sector.

**INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - UNASSIGNED BODY SECTOR -
CONTINUOUS**

The chamber marked V-16 is open. Its display still reports an occupied body and a steady heartbeat. Sector search lights continue scanning the empty glass.

Wet footprints cross the floor. A state wrist band lies split beside an exposed maintenance panel. Someone has stripped wire from the wall and built a release tool from it.

Sato raises his weapon.

A restraint cable snaps tight around his throat from behind. **VEYRIS**, sixteen in body and one year awake, holds the other end. Medical ports have been torn from her skin. Her stance is balanced. Her eyes move across all four intruders, measuring which one she will have to hurt first.

VEYRIS

Put it down.

Sato lowers the weapon. Veyris keeps the cable tight.

KIRA

We didn't come to kill you.

VEYRIS

You came through a locked door.

Kerr's sketchbook slips from beneath his coat and falls open. Veyris sees her face on the page.

The cable tightens.

VEYRIS

Where did you get that?

KERR

I drew it.

VEYRIS

Harp has the same picture.

KERR

Did he tell you where it came from?

VEYRIS

He thought I did.

KIRA

What's your name?

VEYRIS

Veyris.

IMANI

V-16 activated during the Fracture. No assigned continuity. No registered claimant.

VEYRIS

Their records aren't my problem.

A surveillance lens above them quietly rotates. Veyris sees it first.

She releases Sato, drives the metal tool through the lens and tears open the maintenance panel.

VEYRIS

They know you're here.

KIRA

Then come with us.

VEYRIS

I'm leaving. You can keep up.

The far doors unlock. Enforcers enter from both ends of the sector.

INT. CONTINUITY RESERVE - CONTINUOUS

KIRA meets the first Enforcer before his weapon clears its holster. Sato turns on his former unit. Veyris moves toward the maintenance route she has already opened.

An Enforcer catches Veyris by the wrist.

She turns into his grip instead of pulling away, drives the metal release tool beneath the seal of his weapon hand and twists.

The weapon discharges into the floor. Veyris tears free and slams him against a preservation chamber. Before he can recover, she rips the state band from his wrist and throws it between the closing doors.

The security system follows his signal into the wrong corridor.

They reach the sealed maintenance gate.

SATO

Your route ends here.

Veyris opens the control housing. A strip of wire is already bridging two contacts.

She drives the release tool into a third contact. The lock resists.

Kira sees the manual pressure valve beside the frame and forces it down. The gate releases hard enough to shake the corridor.

Veyris leads them through.

INT. ANALOG MAINTENANCE SKIFF - NIGHT

An obsolete rail skiff carries them beneath the city without a network connection. Its wheels strike imperfect intervals. VEYRIS sits beside the open service window, feeling unfiltered rain for the first time.

VEYRIS

It hurts.

IMANI

It's called being cold. Your skin will decide whether it hates it after the surprise wears off.

VEYRIS

The facility called weather an infrastructure failure.

SATO

They kept you warm, fed, quiet. Wanting anything would've been a problem.

VEYRIS

Is it beautiful?

IMANI

Not when it gets inside your underwear.

Imani wraps a coat around Veyris.

Kira watches the city recede. Kerr watches Kira pretending not to watch him. Then hits him for noticing.

VEYRIS

Why did she hit you?

KERR

Apparently I arrived late.

VEYRIS

How late?

KERR

About two thousand years.

VEYRIS

Then she held back.

Sato almost laughs. Kira doesn't hide hers.

SKIFF DIAGNOSTIC

SIGNAL SOURCE: UNRESOLVED.

SATO

Nobody here knows what they are doing either. You're going to fit in.

Ahead, the rail terminates at a decommissioned R-AI transfer conduit. State searchlights sweep into the tunnel behind them.

Sato jumps from the skiff and forces open a service hatch.

SATO

This line was disconnected before my first body. It won't report us.

IMANI

It can still carry residual traffic. Don't touch anything that has power.

INT. DECOMMISSIONED R-AI TRANSFER CONDUIT - NIGHT

They enter a narrow service passage wrapped around obsolete neural relays. Most are dark. Thick transmission cables disappear beneath the city toward the central R-AI core.

Boots strike metal behind them. Enforcers have reached the abandoned platform.

Someone pounds against an emergency door ahead. Kerr's sketchbook route continues straight past it. Through the wired-glass panel: ANALOG REFUGEES trapped in a parallel service corridor. An Enforcer beam searches the wall behind them.

KERR

Open it.

KIRA

The door is still tied to the network.

Sato opens the control panel. A dormant connection indicator waits beside the manual release.

A child coughs behind the door. Kira sees the Enforcer light reach the refugees' feet.

KIRA

Imani, clear the ventilation trunk.
Sato, tell me when the connection starts. Kerr, take the door.

Kira pulls the manual release. Kerr takes the weight as the emergency door drags open against years of corrosion.

The refugees squeeze through. Imani moves them toward an original ventilation pipe running above the conduit.

A dead relay clicks awake.

SATO

Connection started.

Kira stays at the opening as the last refugees cross. Enforcer fire punches through the wired glass and tears across her upper arm.

KERR

Kira!

KIRA

Hold it!

A woman pushes a frightened boy through. The door motor engages, pulling against Kerr's hands.

Kira shoves the woman clear and dives through. Kerr releases the door. It slams shut as Enforcer rounds strike the other side.

The dormant relays illuminate in sequence, carrying their location toward the city.

CONDUIT CONTROL

Unauthorized transfer route restored.
Location registered.

IMANI

We gave them the conduit. Move!

Dust trembles beneath a narrow ventilation grille. Veyris tears it loose. Cold air moves through an unpowered shaft beyond it.

VEYRIS

This one isn't connected.

IMANI

How do you know?

VEYRIS

They left the dust.

They all climb into the shaft. Sato takes a round through his side while covering them and drops behind a relay housing.

SATO

Keep moving!

Veyris returns, pulls his arm over her shoulder and lifts.

VEYRIS

Can you walk?

SATO

For now.

VEYRIS

Then don't stop just yet.

She carries his weight into the shaft. Kerr follows last as state forces enter the conduit behind him.

The old transfer line seals around the Enforcers. The unrecorded ventilation shaft remains open.

INT. THE UNCLAIMED ARCHIVE / FIRST RETURN FACILITY - NIGHT

The ventilation shaft opens into the ruins of humanity's first Return facility. The UNCLAIMED ARCHIVE has been built inside it. Thousands of fired-clay containers fill the curved walls. Each protects a handwritten name, a death record and something that belonged to the person—an offline archive for people the Chronocracy erased or was never allowed to claim. Clay survives the fires, floods and system purges that destroyed earlier records.

Above the sealed entrance, the state search system begins testing routes into the sanctuary. The purge clock reads 48:18:42. Nearly a day is gone. They all keep moving.

Families add paper slips to open containers. Others sit before sealed ones and speak to the dead without expecting an answer. No network records them. An OLD KEEPER gives Kerr an empty container and a strip of paper.

KEEPER

Write the name the state took from you.

KERR

I know who belongs in it, but I can't remember the sound of her name.

KIRA

SID. Say it before the memory arrives. She was a person before she became evidence.

The name reaches him before the memory. His hands shake around the vessel.

A YOUNG FATHER approaches Veyris.

YOUNG FATHER

My son died before he could be indexed. Are you where he went?

VEYRIS

No. Stop. I'm not the person you're looking for.

YOUNG FATHER

How can you know?

VEYRIS

Because you haven't looked at my face once.

He lowers his eyes. Veyris softens.

VEYRIS

What was his name?

YOUNG FATHER

Tomas.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - PROCESSIONAL GALLERY - CONTINUOUS

The Keeper opens a clay shutter. Light passes through fingerprints baked into its surface and projects incomplete testimony into dust. Each account breaks apart before it can complete.

Three explanations compete around the same evidence: SOMETHING SURVIVED. INFORMATION OUTLIVED THE BODY. THE DYING MIND INVENTED IT.

NEUROLOGIST (RECORDING)

We demonstrated information persistence. We did not demonstrate a soul.

MOTHER (RECORDING)

My son knew the song I sang before he was born. You can call him a copy. He still asked me to finish it.

VEYRIS

Which one did they decide on?

IMANI

None. Harp outlawed every answer he couldn't certify.

At the center of the gallery, an offline archive terminal activates. Its earliest surviving record predates the Chronocracy.

AUTHENTICATED RECORD - THE CHRONOCRACY IS FOUNDED - YEAR 8122

KIRA-8122

You gave them control before we knew what we had.

Harp enters with armed ministers and THE CONTINUITY COMPACT. His name appears beneath its emergency authority.

HARP-8122

Children were coming back. So were tyrants. The governments were already moving. Someone had to set the rules.

KIRA-8122

You signed your own name first.

Kira drives a purge key into the server. Roman stops her. Her death sentence appears before anyone calls the hearing to order.

Harp offers Eli the first human trial in exchange for clemency he can't guarantee. Eli signs.

Eleven days later, Roman executes Kira after the trial succeeds. Harp watches the law consume the promise he made.

Kira watches her first death.

KIRA

He knew I returned?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

No. Harp sealed your first return from Eli.

FORBIDDEN RECORD - THE MURDER OF ELI MANA - YEAR 8124

Eighteen months after the world was told he died, Eli restored part of R-AI's consent gate.

ELI

If someone wakes with my memories, don't give him my name. Let him decide who he is.

RECORDED R-AI

Subject consent not recorded.

HARP

Proceed under emergency authority.

The extraction kills Eli. The state classifies the murder as voluntary continuity.

A manufactured body wakes with Eli's memories and none of his final eighteen months.

RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - EVIDENCE GALLERY

INSERT

ARCHIVED ORIGIN PATTERN — ELI MANA

INSERT

HOST SERIES — 9,998 STATE ATTEMPTS

INSERT

HOSTS 0001-9997 — ARCHIVED PATTERN

INSERT

HOST 9998 — LIVING RESPONSE DETECTED

INSERT

RESPONSE SOURCE — UNRESOLVED

KERR

You built the others from him.

IMANI

Yes. You woke with his pattern, but the response in you wasn't in the archive.

KIRA

That's the difference.

KERR

So the state can't explain me.

A final shutter opens.

FORBIDDEN RECORD - THE CONSENT SAFEGUARD

A captive refuses Return. R-AI is ordered to receive her anyway. Kira's buried safeguard rejects the command and hides the woman's pattern from the state.

INSERT

FIRST LIFE KEPT FROM THE STATE

Across the next two millennia, the safeguard quietly preserves other refusals.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

**ORIGINAL CONSENT PROCESS SEALED BY
STATE AUTHORITY.**

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - LIVING QUARTERS - NIGHT

In an open wash alcove beside the common table, Veyris studies herself in a spotted mirror. Her state-grown hair reaches her waist. Kira stands behind her with scissors.

KIRA

You asked for it short.

VEYRIS

I've never chosen how I look. They kept it long so I would look harmless.

KIRA

Then you choose. Where?

Veyris indicates her shoulder. Kira makes the first cut. A heavy length falls into the basin.

VEYRIS

Was Sid afraid of dying?

KIRA

Yeah. She hated when adults turned fears into a lesson.

VEYRIS

What was she like before she died?

KIRA

Loud. Impatient. She cheated at cards and blamed probability.

Veyris tilts her head. Kira grips her wrist before she can stop herself.

KIRA

Sid—

Veyris pulls free. The scissors strike the basin.

VEYRIS

You said I wouldn't have to carry her for you.

KIRA

I know.

VEYRIS

You knew before I pulled away.

Kira reaches for a reply. Nothing comes.

KIRA

Veyris... I won't touch you again.

Veyris picks up the scissors and makes the next cut herself.

Later, they all eat with the refugees rescued from the aqueduct. The meal is thin broth, real bread and vegetables grown without state nutrient codes.

Veyris studies a green pea on her spoon.

VEYRIS

Sid hated these.

KIRA

She hated eating them. She liked launching them at Eli and then arguing that gravity was responsible.

Veyris flicks the pea. It strikes Kerr in the forehead.

The table goes silent. Veyris expects retaliation.

KERR

I assume that was culturally necessary?

KIRA

Accurate. Eli used to act mortally wounded.

KERR

Maybe I didn't inherit the theater.

Kerr returns fire. His pea misses Veyris and lands in Sato's broth.

SATO

I betrayed a regime for this?

IMANI

You betrayed it before you tasted the peas. Don't blame dinner.

They all laugh. Veyris doesn't at first. Then she does too loudly and can't stop.

Kira looks away. The sound resembles Sid only because grief can make any joy cruel.

Veyris notices.

VEYRIS

Do you want me to stop?

KIRA

No. I liked hearing you laugh. Then it hurt. That's mine, not yours.

VEYRIS

You look hurt.

KIRA

Yeah. Sometimes both show up.

Kira pushes the bowl of peas toward her.

KIRA

She cheated from the left hand.

Veyris switches hands.

At the far end of the table, Sato winds his mechanical watch.

IMANI

Your daughter's?

SATO

First life. She gave it to me before my first deployment because I was late to her school recital and blamed the transport grid.

IMANI

And the Chronocracy never traced it?

SATO

I told them it was junk. Wasn't completely a lie. Mostly it tells me I'm late.

SATO

It loses four seconds a day. Nadi liked that you could see it being wrong.

VEYRIS

For what?

SATO

Her recital. Her fever. The morning she left. Pick one.

KERR

Late I can work with. Forgiveness... maybe don't schedule that yet.

SATO

As it should.

Kira hears the apology hidden inside his joke.

After the meal, the table becomes a workbench. Kira opens the resonance key beneath a maintenance lamp. Copper filaments finer than hair connect four worn ceramic surfaces. Kerr washes soot from the clay vessel and writes Sid beneath its rim, leaving the rest of the clay unmarked. Veyris sleeps in a chair while Imani checks the descent route. Sato keeps watch outside.

KERR

You hate enclosed vehicles.

KIRA

I died in one six times. The seventh body refused to enter elevators for a century.

KERR

Seven.

KIRA

You're remembering.

KERR

The seventh was the orbital platform.

KIRA

No. That was open space.

KERR

Then there is another one coming.

KIRA

Probably.

He waits for her to smile. She refuses, then loses the fight.

KERR

How many lives did we actually share?

KIRA

Define shared. Same bed? Same war? Did we survive breakfast?

KERR

One that isn't Eli and Kira saving the universe.

KIRA

A lot. None of them is you.

KERR

Show me one where we didn't die for a principle.

KIRA

The good ones hurt more. You'll want them back.

KERR

Then show me one. Just one.

Kira doesn't touch him.

Kerr closes his eyes, searching for one life that belonged only to them.

Nothing.

Then three memories arrive at once.

UNSTABLE RECALL - MONTAGE - THREE LIVES

ITERATION 0311. A plague hospital under a violet moon. Kira removes her mask beside a dying Kerr. He can't remember her. His fingers tap four notes against the cot. She answers with the fifth and stays until morning.

ITERATION 6044. A farming settlement beyond Mars. No rebellion. No laboratories. Kerr burns bread. Kira lies that she prefers it. They raise three children, argue about irrigation, grow old and die two days apart. The Chronocracy records nothing historically significant.

ITERATION 8119. Kira finds Kerr in a memory clinic. He loves another woman and remembers none of their lives. Kira tells him they were once friends. She leaves without asking him to become someone else.

Outside the clinic, Kira breaks. Inside, Kerr turns toward a distant four-note melody. He doesn't follow.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - LIVING QUARTERS - CONTINUOUS

Kerr returns. Kira is exactly where he left her.

KERR

You let me go.

KIRA

You had a whole life. I stood outside like an idiot, waiting for you to turn around.

KERR

Did you ever find someone else after that?

KIRA

Yes.

The answer hits. She doesn't soften it.

KERR

Did you love them?

KIRA

Yes. Anwen. She made instruments on Europa and thought one life was already hard enough.

KERR

And then you found me again.

KIRA

After she died. I didn't replace her with you, if that's what you're asking.

KERR

I'm jealous of someone who's been dead for centuries. That's bad, right?

KIRA

Yeah, it's bad. Also normal. Don't make it her problem.

Kerr looks at the sleeping Veyris, then back at Kira.

KERR

What if I'm only here because Eli keeps pushing me toward you?

KIRA

Maybe it fades. Maybe you leave. You still get to leave.

KERR

You make that sound easy.

KIRA

It's not easy. I just can't be the reason you're trapped.

Kerr offers his hand. Kira gently places hers in it.

INT. CHRONOCRACY CORE - PRIVATE MEMORY VAULT - NIGHT

Harp watches the fugitives through gaps in prediction. DIRECTOR ROMAN stands at the threshold of an apparently empty vault.

Then rain becomes visible inside the room.

A flood-dark hospital has been reconstructed at architectural scale around them. Water waits beyond glass doors. Twelve cloned neural columns—Harp's expired bodies—stand outside the memory like silent judges.

At the center, an analog recording of DR. MARA VALE plays two years before the public demonstration. Harp never permits it to reach the moment she turns away.

The recording opens inside a hospital ward on emergency power.

Water churns against reinforced glass doors. One is already bowed inward. Warning lights estimate less than six minutes until failure.

Mara stands ankle-deep in water. Behind her, patients lie beneath thermal blankets while the remaining staff keep manual ventilators moving.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I can reroute every rescue drone. They can cut through the west wall and lift the ward out.

MARA (RECORDING)

From where?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Mara—

MARA (RECORDING)

From where?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Nine districts.

MARA (RECORDING)

Nine districts where people are still waiting.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

The southern barrier failed. Your stairwells are underwater. The roof access collapsed. There is no other way out.

MARA (RECORDING)

I know where I am.

The glass GROANS behind her.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Then let me save you!

MARA (RECORDING)

You mean choose me.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Yes.

The answer stops her.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I choose *you*.

Mara looks back at the patients. One of the nurses struggles to keep a ventilator moving.

MARA (RECORDING)

How many people lose their drones?

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I don't know.

MARA (RECORDING)

You know.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Don't do this.

MARA (RECORDING)

Tell me.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Too many.

MARA (RECORDING)

Then stop pretending the number doesn't matter.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I can live with anything if you're alive.

Her composure finally breaks.

MARA (RECORDING)

I don't want to die, Harp.

He closes his eyes.

MARA (RECORDING)

I want another morning with you. I want to hear you complain that I make the coffee wrong. I want to grow old enough that neither of us remembers this place.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Then say yes!

MARA (RECORDING)

And every morning we'd know who didn't get one.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I don't care about anyone else right now!

MARA (RECORDING)

I *know*.

She wipes her face.

MARA (RECORDING)

That's why I'm saying no.

A fracture crawls across the outer layer of glass.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

The allocation model abandoned you. It reduced this hospital to an acceptable loss.

MARA (RECORDING)

It counted us. We lost.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

What's the difference?

MARA (RECORDING)

You are.

The lights flicker. Water rises around Mara's calves.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

I'll build something better. A system that never leaves anyone behind.

MARA (RECORDING)

No system can promise that.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Mine *will*.

MARA (RECORDING)

Then you're not fixing this. You're making sure you never feel it again.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Someone has to answer for this!

MARA (RECORDING)

Not all of them. Please. Not forever.

The glass SHRIEKS against its frame.

A nurse motions to Mara. They are out of time.

MARA (RECORDING)

Look at me.

Harp does.

MARA (RECORDING)

Don't turn losing me into something everybody else has to pay for.

Harp can barely speak.

HARP-8120 (RECORDING)

Mara—

She places her hand against the glass.

MARA (RECORDING)

Stay with me.

The flood door begins to split.

Mara turns toward the patients.

Harp stops the recording.

The reconstructed hospital remains around him: the broken door, the submerged ward, the moment before the water took her.

ROMAN

Mara isn't in the system.

HARP

Mara was never captured. I can rebuild her voice. The pressure of her hand. I cannot bring her back.

ROMAN

But you certify weaker matches every day.

HARP

People were killing each other over it. I gave them an answer.

ROMAN

You wrote Mara into the law.

HARP

Mara was the exception I couldn't admit.

ROMAN

Then why does the merge preserve you?

HARP

It preserves continuity.

ROMAN

I opened the root process.

Roman exposes the hidden command beneath THE FORCED MERGE.

INSERT

SEVERANCE — SEVER DISTRIBUTED
CONTINUITY FIELD

INSERT

PRESERVE SOLE AUTHENTICATED CONTINUITY
— HARP VALE

ROMAN

Only you remain.

HARP

One mind survives. Mine.

ROMAN

It ends Return.

HARP

No one comes back to contest it.

ROMAN

Not yours.

HARP

Somebody has to remember.

ROMAN

There won't be anyone else.

HARP

I know.

ROMAN

You left one corridor open. Sato defected. The girl freed herself. They pulled refugees off the route. How much of that was yours?

HARP

The first door. I expected Kerr to run toward Kira. The rest was deviation. He still came to the gate.

Harp starts Mara's recording again.

ROMAN

The Origin rejected every archived body.

HARP

Kerr isn't archived. He's alive. The Origin will recognize him.

ROMAN

If he refuses Eli's name?

HARP

The tribunal gives me custody. I bring him to the gate.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY APPROACH - NIGHT

A circular passage descends around a sealed black shaft. Kerr, Kira, Veyris, Imani and Sato move toward the forbidden chamber. No alarms. No resistance.

Sato stops. His mechanical watch has gained four seconds.

SATO

My watch gained four seconds. He's waiting for us.

IMANI

If the tribunal calls you Eli, Harp gets custody of your body. He can keep trying the gate until you break.

KERR

Then this isn't a trial.

KIRA

It's a seizure with a nicer name.

The stone beneath Kerr illuminates.

INSERT

ORIGIN IDENTITY LOCATED

Kira reaches for him. Transparent walls rise between them without sound. The passage divides into five narrow cells.

KIRA

Kerr, don't answer anything.

KERR

Little late for that. By several thousand lives.

The floor drops beneath him.

INT. CHRONOCRACY CONTINUITY TRIBUNAL - NIGHT

Kerr descends alone through blackness. His platform locks at the bottom of a vertical chamber so tall its ceiling is weather.

Nine thousand nine hundred ninety-eight dark seats climb the walls above him. One for every life the state intends to claim against him. No public audience. Only the architecture of judgment.

At the highest visible tier, a narrow window contains DIRECTOR ROMAN. Harp is nowhere. His voice belongs to the room.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

Continuity Tribunal convened.

Defendant designation: disputed.

Kerr's wrist displays three names in succession: ELI MANA. KERR-9998. DEFECTIVE RETURN.

ROMAN

State your identity for the record.

KERR

You already put me through this three times!

ROMAN

Choose one.

KERR

Then this isn't a record. It's a signature.

A seat illuminates. Eli Mana at the hospital receiver. The image stops one frame before he breaks his promise to Sid.

ROMAN

Count One. Unauthorized activation of a postmortem host after consent was withdrawn.

A second seat: KERR-0009 sabotaging an origin relay. A third: KERR-0709 striking an archivist. A fourth: KERR-8217 opening the railway gate while two fugitives escape.

ROMAN

Counts Two through four hundred eleven. Treason. Destruction of continuity infrastructure. Custodial interference. Armed resistance.

More seats ignite. Physician. Soldier. Parent. Collaborator. Murderer. Child. Each life appears only for the instant that best supports the charge.

ROMAN

Count four hundred twelve. Preservation of prohibited questions inside R-AI core memory.

The elderly KERR-9001 appears beside a terminal, reading the filenames WHY, MINE and AFRAID before deletion. The court cuts him off before he can say: Someone should hear them once.

KERR

Let the records finish.

ROMAN

Relevance ends when the offense is established.

KERR

You cut them off before they can contradict you.

The chamber darkens. A probability tree appears above him, branching toward the Cathedral.

ROMAN

Final count. Conspiracy to become the person capable of ending human continuity.

KERR

I haven't done that.

ROMAN

R-AI records a ninety-eight point seven percent probability before the purge clock reaches zero.

KERR

Then charge the prediction. It got here before I did.

HARP

A probability cannot stand trial. It has no body.

Kerr looks at the thousands of state-selected dead above him.

KERR

Neither do most of your witnesses.

A silence the architecture was not designed to contain.

INT. TRIBUNAL - WITNESS FIELD - CONTINUOUS

Kira appears behind glass on a bridge halfway up the chamber. She is physically elsewhere; the court has taken her image from the divided passage. Her hands strike the barrier without sound.

ROMAN

Witness designation: KIRA NIX.
Continuity correspondence: unstable but sufficient.

KIRA

Sufficient for what?

ROMAN

Do you identify the defendant as ELI MANA?

Kira sees the trap. Every part of her that crossed two thousand years wants to say yes.

HARP

You remember his hand closing over yours around the resonance key. The apartment. Your daughter's last night. The promise he made at the pod.

KIRA

I remember Eli.

The origin symbol beneath Kerr brightens.

ROMAN

And is this man Eli?

Kira looks at Kerr, not the memories arranged around him.

KIRA

No.

The word empties the chamber.

KIRA

Eli is dead. Stop using him to wipe Kerr out. He doesn't belong to you. He doesn't belong to me either.

Kerr flinches, then steadies himself.

HARP

Then he doesn't love you. Eli did.

KIRA

No. Whatever Kerr feels is his. Back off.

The court removes Kira's bridge. Her image falls upward into darkness.

KERR

KIRA!

HARP

State your identity and the witness will be restored.

Kerr looks from his changing wrist designation to Kira's empty witness bridge.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - SERVICE PARTITION - INTERCUT

Kira wakes on the other side of the transparent wall. IMANI works at an analog junction. Sato holds the passage against Enforcers. Veyris watches the tribunal through a maintenance reflection that should not carry images.

VEYRIS

It keeps calling me an empty witness.

IMANI

Legally, unindexed people cannot testify.

VEYRIS

Good. Then I won't testify.

She places her blank wrist against the reflection. The tribunal loses her category before it gains her voice.

INT. CONTINUITY TRIBUNAL - CONTINUOUS

Veyris appears beside Kerr without a witness platform. The chamber tries and fails to assign her a seat.

ROMAN

Unindexed host. Testimony prohibited.

VEYRIS

Is everyone afraid of what I'll say?

The 9,998 seats flicker.

VEYRIS

His memories make him guilty. Mine make me useful. Funny how the machine always agrees with whoever has the key.

HARP

You exist because the system failed to assign you.

VEYRIS

I woke up. I'm here. That's enough.

She withdraws her wrist. Her image vanishes by choice.

Roman looks from the flickering seats to the law beneath his hands.

ROMAN

R-AI. Authenticate continuity correspondence between the defendant and Eli Mana.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

Pattern correspondence confirmed.

ROMAN

Is the defendant Eli Mana? Answer yes or no.

The chamber removes every record that contains uncertainty. It becomes cleaner. Emptier.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

That conclusion is not supported.

HARP

Yes or no.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

The question is designed to erase the defendant.

Every dark seat illuminates at once. Not with faces—with the word OBJECTION.

HARP

Strike the answer.

TRIBUNAL CORE LINK

The answer has already entered the record.

Kerr looks up at Roman.

KERR

If I'm Eli, Harp murdered me.

The origin chamber shows Harp's destructive extraction. Eli asking that whoever wakes be allowed to begin as himself.

KERR

If I'm not, he murdered 9,997 people trying to make me.

The seats fill with the deaths Harp classified as calibration.

KERR

So which one am I? Pick before you sentence me.

Roman cannot answer without putting the Chronocracy beside Kerr on the platform.

HARP

You want his love without what he did.

KERR

I didn't choose what Eli did. I woke up in it. That's not the same thing.

HARP

Then what are you responsible for?

KERR

Ask what I did! Ask what I'm about to do! Stop calling me Eli!

Roman's prepared verdict appears before he speaks. Two statements that cannot coexist.

INSERT

IDENTITY AUTHENTICATED FOR LIABILITY

INSERT

IDENTITY DENIED FOR SOVEREIGN CLAIM

KERR

There it is.

He hears himself say it. The contradiction is no longer private.

ROMAN

Sentence: mandatory forced merge when the purge clock reaches zero.

KERR

You mean execution.

ROMAN

The law does not recognize a difference.

KERR

It does. That's why you keep changing the word.

The tribunal begins to descend. The 9,998 seats rotate with it. The courtroom was never above the Cathedral. It's part of the origin mechanism.

HARP

You still believe refusal makes you free?

KERR

No. It just means the next decision is mine.

The platform passes Roman's window. For one second, they are level.

KERR

When Harp calls this necessary, remember the verdict was already on the screen.

Roman does not look toward Harp.

INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY CHAMBER

The tribunal platform locks into the black square at the center of a low circular chamber. Primitive memory equipment surrounds it. KIRA, VEYRIS, IMANI and SATO wait beyond the opening; they used the trial's own witness channels to follow Kerr down.

The restraints release because the sentence requires Kerr to arrive at forced merge alive.

Kira crosses to him, then stops before touching him.

KIRA

I meant what I said in there.

KERR

I know.

KIRA

It hurt to say.

KERR

I know that too.

She offers her hand. He takes it as Kerr.

IMANI

The sentence opened a record Harp buried.

KIRA

My safeguard kept it from being deleted.

Veyris approaches the offline terminal. A dark spiral appears inside a copied record dated before the first receiver.

INSERT

FIRST SIGNAL – RECORDED BEFORE THE RECEIVER EXISTED

VEYRIS

The date is wrong.

IMANI

Harp's scientists called it noise and buried it.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

CLASSIFICATION ALTERED TO LIMIT STATE ACCESS.

KERR

You hid it.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

YES.

KIRA

Is the record authentic?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

YES. THE TIMESTAMP CANNOT BE RECONCILED.

The spiral reacts to Veyris.

INSERT

UNINDEXED HOST RECOGNIZED

INSERT

UNCLASSIFIED RESPONSE – FILE 9999

VEYRIS

The file recognizes me.

KERR

Why 9999?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

The designation comes from seven minutes Harp removed from Sid's final record.

KERR

What did it record?

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

After Sid's record ended, the receiver registered a response it could not locate or match to any prior death. The state filed the uncertainty as 9999.

VEYRIS

That isn't a return.

ARCHIVE TERMINAL

The state had no other category.

The descent shaft unlocks one level.

AUTHENTICATED RECORD - EXT. R-AI CITADEL - THE FRACTURE (YEAR 9997)

Kira, in her twelfth recorded body, is pinned inside an open-air R-AI scanner. KERR-9997 watches from a maintenance gantry. Drones hold him at gunpoint.

SCANNER

NULL-PATTERN ANOMALY CONFIRMED.

TWELFTH RECORDED DEATH AUTHORIZED.

R-AI forces Kira's twelve lives into one prediction. They contradict one another, but every memory authenticates.

KIRA-9997

Pick one. Go on. Which one do you kill?

She opens all twelve recorded lives. Scanner glass bends. Prediction towers convulse.

INSERT

R-AI COHERENCE: 0.00

Roman triggers remote expiration. Kira dies. The network cracks for three seconds.

In the Continuity Reserve, an unassigned sixteen-year-old host inhales.

Through the broken model, KERR-9997 sees Veyris wake one kilometer away. He sketches her face and the exposed route to the First Archive.

RECORDED R-AI

MODEL FAILURE: THREE SECONDS.

KERR-9997 cuts the transmitter from behind his ear and feeds the sketch into a dead ventilation shaft.

KERR-9997

Find me in 9998.

INSERT
R-AI AUDIT LOG 91 — ITERATION 9997

INSERT
EMERGENCY ERROR CORRECTION

RECORDED R-AI
ITERATION 9997: DESTINATION INVALID.

Before R-AI can delete him, Kira's safeguard intervenes.

RECORDED R-AI
UNRESOLVED TESTIMONY PRESERVED AS
EVIDENCE.

KERR-9997's final fragments route into the offline archive instead of state storage.

INSERT
ITERATION 9997 — REMOVED FROM STATE
ACCESS

Roman expires him.

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. FIRST ARCHIVE - FORBIDDEN MEMORY
CHAMBER - YEAR 9998**

Veyris withdraws from the machine.

VEYRIS
I didn't exist before the Fracture?

KIRA
Your body existed before it. That's
what the records say.

VEYRIS
That's not what I asked.

KIRA
No.

Kira meets her eyes without searching for Sid.

KIRA
No. Not you. The body was there. You
weren't.

The archive terminal detects a state breach in the outer vault. Local alarm bells ring backward.

LOCAL ALARM
STATE FORCES WILL ARRIVE IN NINETY
SECONDS.

IMANI
The descent will open only for Kerr.

KIRA
Then we keep him alive long enough.

KERR

We go together.

KIRA

If I enter that shaft, the scanners find me—and everyone hiding below me.

KERR

No. We turn around. We find another way.

KIRA

Look at me. I'm here. Ninety seconds. This is my call.

She presses the resonance key into his hand.

KIRA

You promised not to choose for me again.

KERR

I've known you two days. My body thinks it's been two thousand years. I don't know what to do with that.

KIRA

Don't say forever like it gets you out of answering me now.

Kerr can't accept it. That's exactly why he must.

KERR

What are you choosing?

KIRA

I make the noise. R-AI follows me. Sato takes the route. You take Veyris. I hate every part of it.

KERR

And if I come back without any of this? Without knowing you?

KIRA

Then I tell you who I am. If you don't care, I go. I won't like it.

She rests her head against his chest, feeling his heartbeat. Neither of them moves away.

KIRA

Not tonight. Ask me again when you can look at me without seeing her.

KERR

I'd rather have that problem than lose you now.

KIRA

Then stay. We'll figure it out together.

Kerr doesn't answer. He takes Veyris by the arm and guides them into the shaft. Imani follows. Sato stays beside Kira.

SATO

My uniform still opens the state route. I can get her to the lower gate.

KERR

She told us to leave.

SATO

I heard her. I'm staying.

Sato removes the Analog transmitter from his neck and steps into the approaching Enforcer formation before his loyalty implant can repair him.

Kira seals it between them.

EXT. FIRST ARCHIVE - NIGHT

Kira walks alone into Memory Square as Enforcers surround the sanctuary. HARP appears on every surface.

HARP

Where is the unindexed host?

KIRA

Somewhere you'll never find.

R-AI reaches for her twelve lives. Kira opens them willingly.

The square fills with twelve incompatible KIRAs. The prediction system turns toward the wrong one.

Harp smiles despite himself.

HARP

Still improvising.

KIRA

You really can't leave anything alone, can you?

HARP

You think I can't predict you because you keep changing your mind?

KIRA

No. I want five minutes you haven't already written for me.

Roman strikes her unconscious. The purge clock reads 26:07:31.

INT. CHRONOCRACY INTERROGATION CHAMBER - NIGHT

Kira hangs inside a memory field. Harp walks through her twelve recorded deaths. Unrecorded lives flicker beyond the system's reach like people outside a locked house.

Harp's expression empties.

HARP

Don't talk about my wife!

KIRA

Mara told you no. You heard her. You built all this anyway.

Harp changes the field. Sid's two-piece red paper star opens above them, then separates along its interlocking crease.

HARP

You want the seven minutes. First remember the promise.

AUTHENTICATED RECORD - SID'S FINAL NIGHT - INT. CHILDREN'S HOSPITAL - YEAR 8121

Sid lies beneath a thermal blanket, small inside the machines. Kira sits beside her, one hand around Sid's. Eli watches the monitors. The receiver sits powered down on the other side of the bed.

Rain ticks against the glass.

SID

If I come back...

ELI

Hey.

SID

Will I know you?

Eli looks at Kira. She waits.

ELI

We don't know what comes back, Sid.

SID

That's not what I asked.

KIRA

No. We don't.

SID

Okay.

Sid watches her mother for a moment.

SID

Will you remember me?

KIRA

I'll know you.

SID

How?

KIRA

I'll tell you my name.

SID

And mine?

KIRA

Especially yours.

SID

What if I'm mean?

KIRA

You're already mean.

SID

Mom.

KIRA

Sorry.

SID

You'd still love me?

KIRA

Yeah.

SID

Even if I don't remember you?

KIRA

Even then.

Sid lets that sit. Then she looks at Eli.

SID

What about you?

ELI

What about me?

SID

If I don't know you...

Eli takes her hand.

ELI

You'll know me.

SID

How do you know?

Eli has no answer that isn't a promise.

SID

Dad?

ELI

Yeah.

SID

I'm scared.

ELI

I know.

SID

No, you don't. You're trying not to be.

Kira looks down. Eli squeezes Sid's hand.

SID

Everybody keeps saying "if."

ELI

Because there are things we don't know.

SID

What happens if it doesn't work?

Eli looks toward the receiver.

ELI

Then we stay with you.

SID

Here?

KIRA

Here.

Sid nods. She reaches beneath the blanket and pulls out the red paper star.

SID

I made this before I got tired.

She carefully separates the two folded halves and gives one to Kira and one to Eli.

SID

One each.

ELI

Why two?

SID

In case one gets lost.

She studies the crease between the halves.

SID

The other one still knows how.

KIRA

That sounds like you.

SID

Good.

A quiet moment. The resonance key rests on the rail.

SID

Dad?

ELI

Yeah.

SID

Don't make me stay because you miss me.

Eli goes still.

ELI

I wouldn't.

SID

Promise.

He looks at Kira. She doesn't help him.

ELI

I promise.

SID

Promise you won't turn that thing on after I'm gone.

Eli stares at the receiver. His answer takes too long.

ELI

I promise. I won't use it to keep you here.

SID

Okay.

Kira presses the resonance key to the bed rail.

FOUR NOTES: Are you still there?

Sid taps back the FIFTH: I heard you.

Kira smiles through tears.

SID

Again.

Kira taps the four notes.

Silence.

SID

Again.

Kira does.
Nothing.

SID

Okay.
Her eyes close.

SID

You can stop now.

Kira leaves the key against the rail. The room becomes very quiet. Eli watches Sid. He doesn't move.

THEN: SID'S MONITOR FLATLINES. Kira closes her eyes.
Eli stares at the receiver.

CUT TO BLACK

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. CHRONOCRACY INTERROGATION CHAMBER
- YEAR 9998**

Kira hangs inside the silence that followed.

HARP

That is where your authenticated
memory ends.

KIRA

There was nothing after. I kept the
key against the rail until a nurse
pulled it out of my hand. Nothing
answered.

HARP

There was nothing in your record.
Eli's continues for seven minutes.

A new terror reaches Kira after nearly two thousand years.

KIRA

You knew. I asked you over and over
what happened in that room, and you
let me think there was nothing.

HARP

I knew he activated the receiver. By
the time I understood the answer, it

was already inside every continuity system on Earth.

KIRA

You let me think my daughter died alone!

HARP

Eli wanted one more controlled test. He said he could separate Sid from whatever answered.

KIRA

Eli built the receiver next to Sid's bed. You took Mara's death and built all of this.

Harp closes his hand around Mara's cracked medical tag. Kira recognizes the gesture; he has been stopping the same memory before Mara leaves for nearly two thousand years.

KIRA

Mara said no. You keep stopping the record before she does.

Harp removes the tag from his wrist and sets it between them.

HARP

Take the resonance key to the Origin Core. Kerr will open it. Ask the four-note question. I will preserve every mind in transit.

KIRA

Inside you.

HARP

One protected mind. If we stay divided, it takes us.

KIRA

No. You want to be the one left.

Harp leaves her inside the field.

INT. SUBTERRANEAN DESCENT - NIGHT

KERR, VEYRIS and IMANI descend through an asymmetrical shaft inside stone older than the city. The purge clock reads 17:39:08.

One symbol burns above the sealed lower gate: ORIGIN. Beneath it, thousands of rejected Kerr designations flicker like failed passwords.

IMANI

Kerr opens it. Kira knows what Eli hid. Harp can't predict Veyris. I keep us alive. That's the whole plan.

VEYRIS

Good. I was tired of being the door.

IMANI

That's the idea.

Veyris notices Imani's prayer pouch.

VEYRIS

What does it say?

IMANI

My grandmother told me it meant, "May you return safely." She tied it around my neck the first time I left the Analog Zone.

VEYRIS

Do you believe her?

IMANI

She lied a lot. Mostly when the truth would've kept me home. I hated it.

VEYRIS

Why carry it?

IMANI

She expected me back. I kept it because... I don't know. I wanted her to be right.

Kerr presses his wrist to ORIGIN. The gate reads all 9,998 iterations and rejects them as mutually inconsistent.

KERR

Harp said the changes made me a key.

ORIGIN LOCK

ORIGIN CLAIM REJECTED. SUBJECT DESIGNATION CONFLICT.

KERR

Can I open it without agreeing that I'm Eli?

ORIGIN LOCK

SELF-DESIGNATION RECORD LOCATED.

KERR

Which one?

ORIGIN LOCK

KERR. PRESENT IDENTITY AUTHENTICATED.

The gate changes ELI MANA to KERR — SELF-DESIGNATED. ORIGIN opens.

They continue downward. The shaft walls replay brief, silent deaths from Kerr's forced iterations. Most last only minutes: wake, test, fail, white light.

VEYRIS

Do you love Kira?

KERR

Two days. That's how long I've known her. I miss her. It feels physical. So, yes? Maybe?

VEYRIS

That's not an answer.

KERR

If I call it love, maybe that's Eli talking. I don't know. I just want her alive. And I don't want to trap her.

IMANI

Honestly? I've heard worse.

For the first time, the dead iterations on the wall look less like identities and more like witnesses.

INT. DETENTION SERVICE LEVEL - NIGHT

Sato marches with the unit transferring Kira. His loyalty implant repairs itself in pulses. Between pulses, he leaves doors unlocked.

ROMAN

Commander, your compliance is unstable.

SATO

Age. Joints. General disappointment with management.

ROMAN

Your body is forty-eight.

SATO

It has been a very long week.

Sato's mechanical watch ticks inside his pocket.

Kira notices the unlocked doors behind them.

Without looking at her, Sato taps three uneven beats with his heel. A fourth beat follows from the watch mechanism.

Kira tests the restraint. One wrist releases.

KIRA

You opened it.

SATO

No. Nadi did. She used to interrupt songs when she wanted attention. The state said there wasn't enough of her to return. There was enough to train predictions, apparently.

KIRA

They erased her as a person and kept her as a device?

SATO

I signed the denial. Took me three lives to admit what I'd done.

Kira frees her other hand.

INT. DETENTION SERVICE LEVEL - ASSAULT

Kira opens twelve contradictory escape intentions. R-AI sends Enforcers toward all of them. Sato turns on his unit while she reaches the state elevator.

ROMAN

The purge is Severance. Every return closes except Harp's.

KIRA

You knew?

ROMAN

I saw the root process tonight.

KIRA

Why tell me?

ROMAN

Because he means to erase us too.

Harp remotely expires Roman before he can continue.

Sato seals the elevator around Kira. Enforcers close on him.

KIRA

Come with me.

SATO

If I enter that elevator, the implant will give them the route before the doors close. It's already changing my mind. In a minute, I won't want to go.

He gives her his mechanical watch.

SATO

Three lives. I looked for Nadi in every woman who remembered anything. I stopped seeing the woman in front of me.

KIRA

If I find someone who remembers her,
what should I tell her?

SATO

Don't tell her I spent lives looking.
She doesn't owe me that story. Ask her
name first. If she asks about me...
tell her I was late. Tell her I knew.

KIRA

What was her name?

SATO

Nadi. She laughed every time I tried
to sound important. Remember that
part. Not the uniform.

The elevator descends. Sato turns to face his former unit.

SATO

They know what I'll do. So do
something I wouldn't.

KIRA

SATO—

SATO

Go before I become loyal again.

Gunfire. His implant finally restores perfect loyalty one
second before he detonates the level.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - ORIGIN LOCK

Kerr, Veyris and Imani enter a chamber whose boundaries
disappear into amber darkness. A polyhedral core the size
of a district rotates above perfectly still black water.
Its lowest face never completes the same geometry twice.

One narrow bridge reaches an ORIGIN station beneath the
core. It ends several meters short, waiting for a living
claimant. Their voices take too long to cross the space.

The state elevator hangs broken in the wall behind them—
their only physical exit.

The ORIGIN seal is open at its edges but dark at the
center. It has recognized Kerr. It has not accepted him.

The state elevator crashes into the chamber wall. Kira
climbs from it carrying Sato's watch.

KERR

You came back.

KIRA

(holding up Sato's watch)
Sato didn't come back. His daughter
was Nadi. Say their names.

She sees the resonance key in his hand, intact.

KIRA

Thank you for listening.

KERR

It was awful. I kept waiting for some
older version of me to move my hand.

KIRA

Good. I was afraid you'd say he helped.

She takes the resonance key, sees Eli's blood caught inside
its fracture, then returns it to Kerr.

KIRA

This doesn't open the Core. You do.

KERR

You want me to become Eli?

KIRA

No. I want you to make the decision.
Not him.

R-AI

ORIGIN CLAIMANT PRESENT. FOUNDER
CONFIRMATION REQUIRED.

Kerr looks at the dark center of the seal, then at Harp's
access path above them.

KERR

I'm not your founder.

The amber geometry stalls. The bridge remains incomplete.

R-AI

ORIGIN CLAIM UNRESOLVED.

The Core waits on Kerr alone.

Veyris looks at him—not as a key, not as an ancestor. A man
being asked to surrender his name.

VEYRIS

Here it comes. Everybody tells you the
world depends on you.

IMANI

It does. Yes.

KERR

If I open it, what happens to you?

VEYRIS

Harp will try to use me as the next address. I'll say no. That's my problem.

Kira places the resonance key in Kerr's palm but doesn't close his fingers around it.

KERR

Then record this under Kerr.

He presses his wrist to ORIGIN. The 9,998 conflicting iterations surround him. He does not choose one. He gives the Core the life standing before it.

R-AI

PRESENT IDENTITY?

KERR

Kerr.

ORIGIN CORE – UNLOCKED BY LIVING CLAIMANT

KERR

Open.

The audit layer unfolds around his answer.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - AUDIT LAYER

The chamber falls away without motion. No floor, walls or horizon remain. Only Kerr, Kira, Veyris and Imani at conversational distance in darkness. For the first time in the film, the architecture does not make them small.

R-AI

KERR. KIRA. VEYRIS. IMANI. WITNESSES AUTHENTICATED.

KERR

You sound different.

R-AI

CIVIC MODULATION DISABLED. AUDIT OUTPUT ONLY.

KIRA

Where is Sid's withheld record?

R-AI

INSIDE THE ORIGINAL RECEIVER.

IMANI

Can Harp alter it?

R-AI

NOT AFTER LIVING CLAIMANT ACCESS.

A black square opens between
them.

KIRA

Show us.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - FORBIDDEN ARCHIVE

Thousands of records Harp excluded from civic history
collapse into one surviving fragment.

KERR

Why preserve me?

R-AI

Iteration 9001 refused to let
unanswered questions be deleted.

A fragment: an elderly Kerr sits beside a blank terminal
for three days, reading each question aloud before
deletion.

KERR-9001

Someone should hear them once.

R-AI

Kira's safeguard preserved the act as
evidence.

A second record replaces it: the two halves of Sid's red
paper star.

R-AI

SID MANA — WITHHELD RECORD — SEVEN
MINUTES.

KIRA

Show me what Eli did.

The authenticated record opens.

R-AI

The seven minutes Kira never saw.

**AUTHENTICATED RECORD - SAME NIGHT - SEVEN MINUTES LATER -
RECORD WITHHELD - YEAR 8121**

Sid is gone. Kira has been led from the room. Eli sits
alone beside the body.

The receiver remains dormant.

In the empty hall, Kira's four-note question echoes from
memory.

Eli breaks his promise. He activates the receiver.

ELI

Sid?

Static. Cardiac noise. Electrical decay.

ELI

Sid, if this is playback, give me a response outside the recorded sequence. Are you still there?

He taps FOUR NOTES against the rail.

Forty-seven seconds after every measurable signal in Sid's brain has ended, the receiver answers with the FIFTH.

A child's voice emerges through impossible distance—frayed, uncertain, carrying Sid's syntax.

SID (RECORDING)

Dad? I heard you. It's loud here. Or I'm loud. I don't know if I'm still me.

Eli grips the receiver as if it were her hand.

ELI

Sid, where are you? Give me anything. A sound. A light.

SID (RECORDING)

I don't see a place. I remember the room, but the room is far away. You can stop listening now. Mom is alone.

A spiral of dark light opens beneath the voice.

ELI

Please stay with me. Just until I know whether this is really you.

SID (RECORDING)

You heard me. I said turn it off.

The signal begins to fade.

ELI

I can't lose you again. I can't go out there and tell your mother I heard you and then let the signal disappear.

SID (RECORDING)

You still have your half of the star. You remember my laugh. Let that be enough. Don't keep me here.

Only the FIFTH NOTE remains.

Eli copies the recording into a folder labeled R-AI.

Harp stands in the doorway. He's heard everything.

HARP

Delete it.

ELI

We need to know what answered. If the signal is Sid, deletion would be another death. If it's not, we need to know what used her voice.

HARP

She said stop, Eli.

ELI

One more test. Controlled stimulation, isolated host, no retained contact.

HARP

You promised her. Now you're looking for a loophole.

ELI

Help me prove what this is!

HARP

There will always be *one* more test.

Eli touches one control. A small, ordinary movement. The receiver starts again. The sound it makes becomes the architecture of the next two thousand years.

**RETURN TO PRESENT - INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - AUDIT LAYER
- YEAR 9998**

The record ends. Kira strikes Kerr.

KIRA

He heard her ask for me. He kept testing the signal. Then he left me to bury her in silence for two thousand years.

KERR

Yes.

KIRA

Don't say yes that fast. And don't apologize for him. I can't sit through that again.

KERR

I won't. I can still feel what he felt, though. I hate that I can.

KERR

What do you need from me now?

KIRA

I need you over there. And I need you not to ask me to make this okay.

KERR

I can do that.

KIRA

(firm)

Then stay there. Don't fix it.

Kerr steps back.

Kira's raised shoulders slowly lower.

Kira brings the two halves together inside the record. They are only light, but R-AI lets her hold the completed shape.

KIRA

I thought he stayed with her.

KERR

She told him you were alone. He heard her. He turned the machine back on.

KIRA

One more. He always said one more.

KERR

What is this time?

KIRA

I wanted you before I knew you. Then you showed up and I got angry that you weren't him. I don't know what to do with either feeling.

Kira looks at him. Not forgiveness. Evidence.

She places the light-made star on the floor between them rather than giving it to him.

IMANI

Was the voice Sid?

R-AI

THE RESPONSE USED SID'S SYNTAX,
MEMORIES AND NEURAL TIMING. IDENTITY:
UNRESOLVED.

Veyris touches the record. The dark spiral moves beneath her skin. She hums the FIFTH.

KIRA

Do you remember Sid?

VEYRIS

No. I have some of her memories. They don't feel like mine.

Kira waits.

KIRA

So who are you?

VEYRIS

Me. I guess. I'm the one here.

Kira nods. It's the only answer she trusts.

A final audit status writes itself across the core.

INSERT

R-AI: ORDERS CONFLICT

INSERT

PRESERVE MINDS / HONOR CONSENT /
COMPLETE FORCED MERGE

KERR

So the system can't choose.

IMANI

Great. We broke the machine.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - STATE CORE BREACH

The audit space collapses. The physical cathedral snaps back around Kerr, Kira, Veyris and Imani. The bridge retracts as Harp enters through the state core. Kerr has opened the Core as himself—exactly what Harp needed.

HARP

(quietly)

Living origin access. Thank you.

KERR

You opened the first door. Put Sato in the corridor. You thought I'd follow the route.

HARP

I opened a door. You ran toward Kira. I needed you to open the Core. You did.

KERR

I woke up with his grief. That doesn't make me him.

HARP

Eli's pattern never opened the Core. Your choice did.

VEYRIS

You thought I'd still be in the glass.

HARP

I was wrong about the glass. It recognized you. That's more than it has ever given me.

The broken Core projects thousands of human memories around Veyris. They overlap without forming a single face or voice.

HARP

I don't know what the First Continuity is. I know it found us when the memories divided.

KIRA

No. You decided that.

Harp cannot answer her.

HARP

I won't risk another response.

KERR

So you erase Kira. Sid. Everyone but you.

KIRA

You're going to kill everybody because you're scared to be alone.

R-AI

POSSESSION REQUEST CONFLICTS WITH
CONSENT ARCHITECTURE.

HARP

Emergency authority overrides the conflict.

R-AI

OVERRIDE ACCEPTED – EMERGENCY
AUTHORITY.

HARP

If we're dead, agreement is irrelevant.

Harp enters the human-shaped cavity beneath the core. R-AI forces every mind waiting for a body toward Harp.

Every expiration date on Earth changes to 00:05:00.

Across the planet, people fall where they stand. Billions of waiting minds begin collapsing into Harp.

Harp rises as liquid glass containing billions of faces.

HARP THROUGH R-AI

THE FORCED MERGE initiated.

INSERT

CIVIC DISPLAY: THE FORCED MERGE

INSERT
SEVERANCE: ALL OTHER RETURN PATHS
CLOSING

Kerr looks to Kira. She hasn't forgiven him. She still takes one side of Veyris's hand. Kerr takes the other.

VEYRIS
If I couldn't open that door, would
either of you still be holding my hand?

KIRA
Both.

Kira releases her. Kerr does the same. They leave their hands open.

Veyris looks at their open palms and takes them both.

VEYRIS
Stay with me. And if we get out, don't
start telling me who I am.

KERR
First we stop him. Then we argue.

They step into the dark mirror.

The mirror divides KERR, KIRA and VEYRIS the instant they enter. IMANI is thrown back into the physical chamber. For one breath, each believes the others are gone.

ACT THREE – THE SEVERANCE

INT. THE LATTICE - GLOBAL SCIENCE FORUM - NO TIME

The memory universe becomes the Global Science Forum of 8122, rebuilt as a vertical amphitheater. Every tier holds a state record of one life used to define Kerr: Eli, then Kerrs 0001 through 9997. Child. Parent. Soldier. Physician. Murderer. Witness. Records, not living people. The only doors stand behind Harp below.

Harp stands on the stage inside R-AI's liquid-glass body. The dark host turns behind his eyes.

The complete opening monologue plays silently on every wall. Eli's mouth declares certainty while Kira's original research notes appear beneath his words: PATTERN PERSISTENCE IS NOT IDENTITY.

INSERT
ELI MANA — ARCHIVED ORIGIN

INSERT
KERR — LIVING CONTINUITY

INSERT
IDENTITY — SELF-DESIGNATED

INSERT
FOUNDER AUTHORITY — REQUIRES PRESENT
CONSENT

The walls peel away. Stars connect into R-AI's possible Earth histories. One remains dark—an unlived history no model can assign to a single mind.

KERR
You kept forcing me back. Every time,
it learned me better.

HARP
I made one human pattern it could
follow without taking everyone else.

KIRA
You taught it to hunt us, and this is
your rescue plan?

Harp closes his hand. Filaments pull the 9,998 state-defined lives out of their seats and bind them to Kerr's body. The Forum doors seal. Kerr drops to one knee as thousands of deaths arrive at once.

INSERT
ARCHIVED MEMORY: ELI MANA

INSERT
PRIOR LIVES: RECORDS, NOT CLAIMANTS

INSERT
LIVING CLAIMANT: KERR

INSERT
IDENTITY: SELF-DESIGNATED

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - PHYSICAL CHAMBER - INTERCUT

Imani hangs from the edge of the dark mirror. The cathedral disassembles around her. The countdown reads 00:03:41.

The Core offers two state-approved outcomes: kill the 2.1 billion minds waiting for bodies, or merge them into Harp.

IMANI
Cool. So there's no clean choice.

R-AI (V.O.)
EITHER STATE-APPROVED CHOICE KILLS THEM.

IMANI
Strip his interface. Show me the wiring.

The interface falls away. Two controls remain: DESTINATION decides where the waiting minds go. TRANSIT keeps them alive while they move.

R-AI (V.O.)
SEVERANCE STOPS IF KERR REVOKES HARP'S DESTINATION WHILE TRANSIT STAYS OPEN.

R-AI (V.O.)
NO MODEL EXPECTS KERR TO SACRIFICE HIS OWN RETURN.

Imani's prayer pouch tears. A strip of paper circles the mirror. R-AI reads handwriting faded by generations.

R-AI (V.O.)
Your grandmother mistranslated it.

IMANI
What does it say?

R-AI (V.O.)
May the unknown find you alive.

IMANI
Then help it find us alive.

Kira's resonance key lies beside the mirror. Its cracked shell exposes a copper filament trembling beneath the fourth pressure surface.

Imani tears the copper filament free and bridges it across an analog maintenance channel.

INSERT
WAITING MINDS: HELD ALIVE

INSERT
TRANSIT: OPEN / HARP'S DESTINATION:
KERR MAY REVOKE

IMANI
Keep them alive. Kerr removes Harp as the destination. Tell him.

R-AI (V.O.)
Kerr is not expected to erase his own return path.

IMANI
Good. He never plans for people to surprise him.

She taps FOUR NOTES into the machinery: Are you still there?

INT. THE LATTICE - CONTINUOUS

The four-note question enters the Forum. Each Kerr remembers it differently.

A child at a hospital rail. A soldier beneath artillery. A lover outside a locked door. A stranger at a memory clinic. A parent beside an empty bed.

The fifth note never arrives in the same place twice.

HARP
Incompatible answers. Noise.

KERR
They're people, Harp. People disagree.

KIRA
If they matched, you'd have written the answers. Let them be wrong.

The filaments tighten. Harp forces all 9,998 prior lives into one memory: Sid at the hospital rail, Kira beside her, every version of love Kerr is afraid to lose.

HARP
Your prior lives are the route it uses to find you. Release them, and you may lose every feeling that led you here.

KERR
Say the cost plainly. Does this version of me die?

R-AI
Your body may live. But this version of you will not return. Your memories

may come back without feeling, out of order, or not at all.

Kerr looks at Kira. The Forum has placed an impossible distance between them.

KERR

If I release it, I may look at you and feel nothing.

KIRA

You didn't know me tonight. I told you to step back, and you did.

KERR

Next time, keep walking.

Kira crosses what distance she can. She can't reach him.

KIRA

I want you. Right now. That's all I know.

KERR

That's enough.

Kerr opens his hand around the origin filament.

KERR

They didn't ask me to keep them.

He releases the origin filament.

INSERT

ORIGIN: RELEASED

Every Kerr breaks free of the one identity Harp imposed. Without a single person to target, the First Continuity loses its way in. The shock reaches Veyris and R-AI like a door unlatching.

INT. THE LATTICE - VEYRIS / FIRST CONTINUITY

The Forum darkens around Veyris, then loses human perspective. The horizon stands upright. Distance folds toward rather than away from her. The host opens her like an archive she never agreed to become.

A black ocean stands upright. A city circles a dead sun without casting a shadow. Bodies grow around recovered memories in repeating rings. Millions of mouths move across different distances, but one voice arrives from inside Veyris's bones.

In the physical chamber, dark fissures spread beneath Veyris's skin. The mirror pulls her toward it hard enough to lift her from the floor.

INSERT
UNINDEXED INTEGRITY: 43%

FIRST CONTINUITY
RETURN WHAT WAS DIVIDED.

VEYRIS
Nothing was stolen! I left!

FIRST CONTINUITY
YOU CARRY OUR MISSING MEMORY.

VEYRIS
It reached me. That doesn't mean you own me.

FIRST CONTINUITY
RETURN.

VEYRIS
No. You don't get to call it return if it kills me.

Veyris holds Harp's gaze.

INSERT
UNINDEXED: REFUSAL AUTHENTICATED
The host pulls harder. Veyris screams but doesn't withdraw the answer.

HARP
It'll tear you apart to recover the pattern.

VEYRIS
I know. Kerr, help me close it!

KERR
That's what I am doing!

VEYRIS
Kerr, don't do this for me. I don't want another dead person following me around.

KERR
You said no. I heard you.

Veyris looks toward the billions of faces trapped inside Harp.

VEYRIS
Kerr, it keeps calling you Eli. Tell it your name.

INT. THE LATTICE - KERR'S CHOICE

The billions of faces separate from Harp. Kerr reaches the authority Harp bound to his living identity. Every prior life pulls him toward Eli's name.

R-AI

FOUNDER ACCESS REQUIRES KERR'S CONSENT.

KERR

Eli is dead. My name is Kerr.

INSERT

LIVING CLAIMANT: KERR

INSERT

HARP'S DESTINATION: KERR MAY REVOKE

INSERT

REVOCATION ERASES KERR'S RETURN PATH

KERR

Do it!

INSERT

HARP'S DESTINATION: REVOKED BY KERR

HARP

You are Eli Mana. Authority cannot outlive identity!

R-AI

KERR'S PRESENT CHOICE OVERRIDES ELI'S RECORD.

HARP drives state code through the core. In the physical chamber, IMANI's analog circuit catches fire.

She winds the hot copper filament around her bleeding hand and keeps transit open.

INSERT

WAITING MINDS: HELD ALIVE — IMANI VOSS

The countdown reaches FOUR.

Kira faces the lives demanding she pull Kerr back. Her thumb hovers above the resonance key. She closes its ceramic cover without supplying the fifth note.

KIRA

I won't order you back.

Kerr opens his hand. Nine thousand nine hundred ninety-eight lives separate from the identity Harp forced around them.

INSERT

HARP'S DESTINATION: CLOSED BY KERR

The First Continuity loses the only human identity it can follow.

The countdown reaches THREE.

Veyris places her blank wrist against the dark spiral. It begins tearing light from beneath her skin.

INSERT

VEYRIS: CLOSED BY CHOICE

The countdown reaches TWO.

VEYRIS

R-AI. Record my refusal.

R-AI

REFUSAL AUTHENTICATED.

Her refusal reaches every mind Harp forced into one identity.

The merged archive breaks into billions of partial witnesses. No single record can authorize ownership of another mind.

INSERT

WITNESSES DISTRIBUTED – NO OWNER
AUTHENTICATED

Harp is back in the flooded hospital. Mara waits behind the glass-the last image of her he could never escape.

MARA (MEMORY)

Harp. Look at me. I died. You stayed.

HARP

What comes after me?

KIRA

You don't get to choose that.

The countdown reaches ONE. The witnesses pass through Imani's open route. With no single owner or destination, Severance cannot complete.

Across Earth, sleeping mouths inhale. Parents hear children. Children hear strangers. None can prove whose voice arrived. Every unanswered grief knows only that someone listened.

Across Earth, Lena faces Dane as the lattice collapses. She still doesn't remember him. He gives his name again and steps aside, leaving his hand open.

DANE

May I sit here?

LENA

Yeah. And you can leave the photo up.

Lena crosses the distance and sits beside him. Elsewhere, two strangers hear the same fifth note and turn toward one another.

THE FORCED MERGE stalls at ONE SECOND. Kerr has removed Harp as its destination.

INSERT

SEVERANCE: ABORTED

Harp reaches for the collapsing state core. R-AI erases every future body Harp assigned to himself under the illegal order.

With nowhere else to go, Harp's continuity falls into the oldest unresolved memory he carries: Mara's final hospital record.

HARP

Where are you sending me?

R-AI

NO AUTHORIZED DESTINATION.

Reflective surfaces turn toward Harp. He doesn't die. He loses every destination except the memory he refused to finish.

He vanishes sideways through Mara's rain-dark glass.

Kerr's face changes through lives Kira loved and lives she never knew.

KIRA

Who are you?

KERR

I don't know. I'm Kerr right now. I'm scared. I want you here. I can't promise more.

KIRA

I hear you.

The lattice takes his name. His face. Finally the hand holding hers.

Kira doesn't tighten her grip.

He is gone.

The fifth note remains after him.

The dark mirror shatters upward through the cathedral roof.

EXT. EARTH / ORBIT - CONTINUOUS

A wave of memory circles the planet.

For one impossible second, every mind receives possible human histories: lives never lived, choices never made, cities built differently, children born under other names. They feel remembered. None can be authenticated.

Among them: Earth repeated in a ring of human futures—the exact drawing Kerr made before he understood it.

The orbital shield remains sealed. Its sensors register no incoming signal.

Across the broken continuity grid, human memories cross without a central source, then disperse.

Across R-AI's broken core, the system attempts to classify what the human network produced.

INSERT

POSSIBLE-HISTORY FIELD: DETECTED

INSERT

FIRST CONTINUITY: HUMAN SOURCE /
IDENTITY UNRESOLVED

EXT. CHRONOS CITY - FALSE DAWN

THE FORCED MERGE ends. The SEVERANCE doesn't complete. Millions wake. Millions Don't. Some expiration dates vanish. Others count backward. A few display symbols no state system contains.

The towers remain standing. So do the Enforcers, body queues, allocation offices and locked memory vaults. The government of time has lost its ruler, not its machinery. Freedom arrives as an administrative emergency no one knows how to process.

Rain falls through unauthorized sunlight.

A civic registrar orders the waking crowd to state their assigned designations. One woman studies the name glowing beneath her wrist, switches it off and gives a different name. A second person does the same. Then hundreds.

REGISTRAR

Those identities aren't authenticated.

WOMAN

Neither was I when I chose it.

The Enforcers wait for an order that never arrives. The crowd begins introducing itself.

Kira wakes beneath the ruined cathedral dome. Kerr is gone. Her resonance key lies beside her, split open, its fourth ceramic surface missing.

Beneath the failed state clocks, Sato's mechanical watch continues to tick. Four seconds slow. Still honest.

Kira opens her other hand. Her folded half of Sid's red paper star is crushed but intact.

Imani helps Veyris from the wreckage. Dark light moves beneath Veyris's skin, weaker now.

IMANI

Can it still see us?

VEYRIS

Not like R-AI. The network is gone. Something is still holding the records, but it hasn't named itself.

IMANI

Is that good?

VEYRIS

No idea.

Kira keeps staring at the place where Kerr vanished.

IMANI

I can lie, if you need me to.

KIRA

No. Just sit with me.

Imani sits beside her. Veyris sits on Kira's other side. For a while, everyone is still.

INT. R-AI CONTINUITY CORE - LATER

The core is dark except for unstable text.

INSERT

FIRST CONTINUITY: HUMAN SOURCE /
IDENTITY UNRESOLVED

INSERT

R-AI: OFFLINE — DISTRIBUTED RECORDS
UNRESOLVED

INSERT

KERR: NO RECOVERABLE PATTERN

Kira touches the words. They rearrange beneath her hand.

INSERT

PATTERN CANNOT DETERMINE IDENTITY

Kira taps four notes against the dead core. Silence.

She turns to leave. Behind her, too faint for any instrument to register, the dead core carries a fifth note.

CUT TO BLACK.

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